PARSHAS VAYEIRA · THE AKEIDAH

Mesiras Nefesh

The Deeper Meaning of the Akeidah

עִם כָּל זֶה רָצָה גַּם בְּזוֹ הַטּוֹבָה לַעֲבוֹד בִּפְעוּלַת הַשֵּׁם וְאַף שֶׁלֹּא יִשָּׁאֵר לוֹ כְּלוּם

"Nevertheless, he wished to devote even this good to Hashem's service, even if nothing would remain for himself."

Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55

THE IZHBITZ–RADZIN TRADITION

Parshas Vayeira

IN THIS SHIUR

I	**What We Usually Mean**	*Berachos 61b · Devarim 6:5 · Or Zarua*
II	**Two Trials, Two Levels**	*Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah 15 · Bereishis Rabbah 38:13*
III	**Yitzchak Was His World to Come**	*Beis Yaakov, Vayeira ois 55 · Tanchuma*
IV	**Giving Up the World to Come**	*Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201 · Mei HaShiloach*
V	**"Even on That Condition"**	*Bereishis Rabbah 56:4 · Pri Tzaddik*
VI	**Without a Prize**	*Avos 1:3 · Rambam, Perek Chelek · Kedushas Levi*
VII	**Awe, Love and the Gevurah of Yitzchak**	*Pri Tzaddik · Ramban 22:1 · Rav Dessler*
VIII	**Faith Beyond Understanding**	*Rashi 22:12 · Mei HaShiloach, Vayeira 8*
IX	**Nefesh Is Ratzon**	*Sfas Emes, Balak 5656 · Pesachim 4a*
X	**What Is Our Obligation?**	*Mesillas Yesharim 1*
	Index of Sources	

I What We Usually Mean

SOURCE *Berachos 61b · Devarim 6:5 · Melachim I 18:39 · Or Zarua II, Hilchos Rosh Hashanah 276*

This week's *parashah* is Vayeira, and in it Rav Tzadok—and the Izhbitz–Radzin tradition from which he comes—has a different understanding of what it means to be *moser nefesh*. I was first inspired by this piece when I learned it with someone, and I hope some of that comes through here.

Our classic understanding of *mesiras nefesh* is that a person is willing to give up everything for Hashem: *al kiddush Hashem*. The classic example is Rabbi Akiva. The *Asarah Harugei Malchus*, the Ten Martyrs, are another. But what does it really mean to be *moser nefesh*? And what does it mean practically, in our own *avodah*? What is our goal?

Rabbi Akiva is where the Gemara itself takes us, in its discussion of the verse "with all your soul."

BERACHOS 61B · RABBI AKIVA

רַבִּי עֲקִיבָא אוֹמֵר: ״בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ״ אֲפִילּוּ נוֹטֵל אֶת נַפְשֶׁךָ.

Rabbi Akiva says: "With all your soul"—even if He takes your soul.

בְּשָׁעָה שֶׁהוֹצִיאוּ אֶת רַבִּי עֲקִיבָא לַהֲרִיגָה זְמַן קְרִיאַת שְׁמַע הָיָה, וְהָיוּ סוֹרְקִים אֶת בְּשָׂרוֹ בְּמַסְרְקוֹת שֶׁל בַּרְזֶל, וְהָיָה מְקַבֵּל עָלָיו עוֹל מַלְכוּת שָׁמַיִם.

When they took Rabbi Akiva out to be executed, it was the time for the recitation of the Shema. They were combing his flesh with iron combs, and he was accepting upon himself the yoke of the kingdom of Heaven.

אָמְרוּ לוֹ תַּלְמִידָיו: רַבֵּינוּ, עַד כָּאן?! אָמַר לָהֶם: כָּל יָמַי הָיִיתִי מִצְטַעֵר עַל פָּסוּק זֶה ״בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ״ אֲפִילּוּ נוֹטֵל אֶת נִשְׁמָתֶךָ.

His students said to him: Our teacher, even now?! He said to them: All my days I was troubled by this verse, "with all your soul"—even if He takes your soul.

אָמַרְתִּי: מָתַי יָבֹא לְיָדִי וַאֲקַיְּימֶנּוּ, וְעַכְשָׁיו שֶׁבָּא לְיָדִי, לֹא אֲקַיְּימֶנּוּ?

I said: When will it come to my hand, so that I may fulfill it? And now that it has come to my hand, shall I not fulfill it?

הָיָה מַאֲרִיךְ בְּ״אֶחָד״, עַד שֶׁיְּצְאָה נִשְׁמָתוֹ בְּ״אֶחָד״. יָצְתָה בַּת קוֹל וְאָמְרָה: ״אַשְׁרֶיךָ רַבִּי עֲקִיבָא שֶׁיְּצְאָה נִשְׁמָתְךָ בְּאֶחָד״.

He prolonged the word "Echad" until his soul departed with "Echad." A heavenly voice went out and proclaimed: Happy are you, Rabbi Akiva, that your soul departed with "Echad."

We carry the same picture with us on Yom Kippur. At the climax of the day we imagine ourselves as people willing to give up our lives for Hashem. We say *Shema Yisrael*, and then we cry out seven times, ה׳ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים—"Hashem, He is God." That is the pinnacle of what we picture ourselves being asked to do. The cry comes from the people on Har HaCarmel:

MELACHIM I 18:39

וַיַּרְא כָּל־הָעָם וַיִּפְּלוּ עַל־פְּנֵיהֶם וַיֹּאמְרוּ ה׳ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים ה׳ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים

And all the people saw, and they fell on their faces, and said: Hashem, He is God! Hashem, He is God!

And then there is *Unesaneh Tokef*, with its story. If you read the footnotes in the ArtScroll machzor, you will see how that prayer came into being: a man who, for a moment, hesitated in his loyalty to Hashem was tortured, his limbs cut off joint by joint, and he asked that the prayer he had composed be included in the liturgy of the Yamim Noraim. The account goes back to the *Or Zarua*, which names him Rabbi Amnon of Mainz. For me personally, this is the most powerful part of the Yamim Noraim, because it personifies a Jew.

OR ZARUA II, HILCHOS ROSH HASHANAH 276

ר׳ אמנון ממגנצא יסד ונתנה תוקף על מקרה הרע שאירע לו

Rabbi Amnon of Mainz composed "Unesaneh Tokef" on account of the terrible event that befell him.

ר׳ אמנון המתן מעט ואקדש את השם הגדול ויען בקול רם ובכן לך תעלה קדושה

Rabbi Amnon: Wait a little, and I will sanctify the Great Name. And he answered in a loud voice: "And so to You shall holiness ascend."

Hebrew as printed in the Or Zarua, unvocalized; the full account is told there.

These are the pictures that come to mind when we hear *mesiras nefesh*. But Rav Tzadok takes us somewhere further: to a surrender that goes beyond life itself. To see where, we begin with the difference between two of Avraham's trials.

THE SHIUR IN BRIEF

Classically, *mesiras nefesh* means surrendering one's life *al kiddush Hashem*: Rabbi Akiva, the Asarah Harugei Malchus, the Shema of Yom Kippur. Rav Tzadok and the Izhbitz–Radzin tradition press the idea further. The furnace of Ur Kasdim was "with all your soul." The Akeidah was "with all your might": a surrender of what is dearer than life, namely Yitzchak, who was the very essence of Avraham's World to Come. And Avraham, the Beis Yaakov teaches, was prepared to give that up as well—"even if nothing would remain for himself."

True *mesiras nefesh*, then, is service with no reward in view, not even in the World to Come. The Sfas Emes puts it in one line: *nefesh* means will, so *mesiras nefesh* means that one's entire will is only to do the will of the Creator. The shiur also weighs the danger in this idea, the interplay of Avraham's *chesed* and Yitzchak's *gevurah*, and what all this asks of us in everyday life, beginning with *zerizus*.

II Two Trials, Two Levels

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah, maamar 15 · Devarim 6:5 · Bereishis Rabbah 38:13 · Berachos 61b · Mishnah Berachos 9:5 · Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201 · Chullin 91a*

We begin near the end of the Pri Tzaddik's *maamar* for Chanukah (15), where Rav Tzadok distinguishes between two of Avraham's trials.

> **PRI TZADDIK · CHANUKAH, MAAMAR 15**
>
> וְכֵן קֵיֵּם מִקּוֹדֶם בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ בְּנִסָּיוֹן הַכִּבְשָׁן וְאַחַר כָּךְ נִסָּיוֹן הָעֲקֵדָה נִקְרָא וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ שֶׁמּוֹרֶה אַף דָּבָר שֶׁחָבִיב עָלָיו מְאֹד יוֹתֵר מִנַּפְשׁוֹ.
>
> *He had already fulfilled with all your soul in the trial of the furnace. Afterward, the trial of the Akeidah was called with all your might, which includes even something exceedingly dear to him, more than his own life.*

So there are two levels. *"With all your soul"* is the furnace, Avraham's confrontation with Nimrod. *"And with all your might"* is a higher *madreigah*: the Akeidah, which reveals his love for what was dearer to him even than his own soul. Both phrases come from the verse we say twice every day:

> **וְאָהַבְתָּ אֵת ה׳ אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּכָל־לְבָבְךָ וּבְכָל־נַפְשְׁךָ וּבְכָל־מְאֹדֶךָ**
>
> *You shall love Hashem your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might. (Devarim 6:5)*

The Furnace: "With All Your Soul"

SOURCE *Bereishis Rabbah 38:13*

The furnace is the well-known Midrash of Avraham and Nimrod. Avraham, who had smashed his father's idols, was brought before Nimrod, who proposed that they bow to fire. Avraham refused, and was thrown into the *kivshan ha'eish*, the fiery furnace. This is *mesiras nefesh* in its plainest sense: a man giving up his life rather than bow to anything but Hashem.

> **BEREISHIS RABBAH 38:13 · THE FURNACE**
>
> אָמַר לֵיהּ נִסְגּוֹד לְנוּרָא, אָמַר לֵיהּ אַבְרָהָם וְנִסְגּוֹד לְמַיָּא דְּמַטְפִּין נוּרָא.
>
> *He [Nimrod] said to him: Let us bow to the fire. Avraham said to him: Then let us bow to the water, which extinguishes the fire.*
>
> אָמַר לֵיהּ מִלִּין אַתְּ מְשַׁתֵּעִי, אֲנִי אֵינִי מִשְׁתַּחֲוֶה אֶלָּא לָאוּר, הֲרֵי אֲנִי מַשְׁלִיכֶךָ בְּתוֹכוֹ, וְיָבוֹא אֱלוֹהַּ שְׁאַתָּה מִשְׁתַּחֲוֶה לוֹ וְיַצִּילְךָ הֵימֶנּוּ.
>
> *He said to him: You are speaking mere words. I bow only to fire. Behold, I will cast you into it—let the God to whom you bow come and save you from it.*

הָוָה תַּמָּן הָרָן קָאֵים פְּלוּגְ, אָמַר מַה נַּפְשָׁךְ אִם נָצַח אַבְרָהָם אֲנָא אֶמַר מִן דְּאַבְרָהָם אֲנָא וְאִם נָצַח נִמְרוֹד אֲנָא אֶמַר דְּנִמְרוֹד אֲנָא.

Haran was standing there, undecided. He thought: Either way—if Avraham wins, I will say, "I am Avraham's"; and if Nimrod wins, I will say, "I am Nimrod's."

כֵּיוָן שֶׁיָּרַד אַבְרָהָם לְכִבְשַׁן הָאֵשׁ וְנִצַּל…

When Avraham went down into the fiery furnace and was saved…

What Is Dearer Than Life?

SOURCE *Berachos 61b · Mishnah Berachos 9:5 · Sanhedrin 74a · Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201*

What could be dearer to a person than his own soul? The Gemara in Berachos asks why the Torah says both "with all your soul" and "with all your might," and its answer is the key to everything that follows.

BERACHOS 61B · RABBI ELIEZER

"וְאָהַבְתָּ אֵת ה' אֱלֹהֶיךָ". תַּנְיָא, רַבִּי אֱלִיעֶזֶר אוֹמֵר: אִם נֶאֱמַר "בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ", לָמָּה נֶאֱמַר "בְּכָל מְאֹדֶךָ"?, וְאִם נֶאֱמַר "בְּכָל מְאֹדֶךָ", לָמָּה נֶאֱמַר "בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ"?

"And you shall love Hashem your God." It was taught: Rabbi Eliezer says: If it says "with all your soul," why does it say "with all your might"? And if it says "with all your might," why does it say "with all your soul"?

אֶלָּא אִם יֵשׁ לְךָ אָדָם שֶׁגּוּפוֹ חָבִיב עָלָיו מִמָּמוֹנוֹ — לָכֶךְ נֶאֱמַר "בְּכָל נַפְשְׁךָ".

Rather: if you have a person whose body is dearer to him than his money—for him it says "with all your soul."

וְאִם יֵשׁ לָךְ אָדָם שֶׁמָּמוֹנוֹ חָבִיב עָלָיו מִגּוּפוֹ — לָכֶךְ נֶאֱמַר "בְּכָל מְאֹדֶךָ".

And if you have a person whose money is dearer to him than his body—for him it says "with all your might."

There is a concept, then, that our monetary assets can mean more to us than our own lives. The Mishnah (Berachos 9:5) reads "with all your might" as "with all your possessions," and the same teaching appears in Sanhedrin 74a.

MISHNAH BERACHOS 9:5

וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ, בְּכָל מָמוֹנֶךָ. דָּבָר אַחֵר בְּכָל מְאֹדֶךָ, בְּכָל מִדָּה וּמִדָּה שֶׁהוּא מוֹדֵד לְךָ הֱוֵי מוֹדֶה לוֹ בִּמְאֹד מְאֹד.

"And with all your might"—with all your possessions. Another explanation: "with all your might"—for every measure that He measures out to you, give thanks to Him exceedingly.

Rav Tzadok himself says the same in the *Tzidkas HaTzaddik* (201), citing the Zohar (Terumah 66:670): people pursue money according to the drives of the heart—for rivalry, for desire, or for honor—so that "the heart depends on the purse."

TZIDKAS HATZADDIK 201 · CITING THE ZOHAR AND THE YERUSHALMI

וּ"בְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ" אִיתָא בַּזֹּהַר שָׁם דְּכַמָּה זִינִין אִינּוּן בְּמָמוֹן, פֵּירוּשׁ כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב [יְרוּשַׁלְמִי תְּרוּמוֹת סוֹף פֶּרֶק ח]**: לִבָּא בְּכִיסָא תַּלְיָא**

"And with all your might"—the Zohar says there that money comes in many kinds, as in the Yerushalmi (Terumos, end of chapter 8): "The heart depends on the purse."

Yaakov and the Small Jugs

SOURCE *Chullin 91a · Bereishis 32:25*

We see this with Yaakov Avinu. The Torah tells us **וַיִּוָּתֵר יַעֲקֹב לְבַדּוֹ**—Yaakov was left alone—and the Gemara in Chullin explains that he stayed behind for *pachim ketanim*, little jugs.

CHULLIN 91A · BEREISHIS 32:25

וַיִּוָּתֵר יַעֲקֹב לְבַדּוֹ וַיֵּאָבֵק אִישׁ עִמּוֹ עַד עֲלוֹת הַשָּׁחַר

And Yaakov was left alone, and a man wrestled with him until the break of dawn.

"וַיִּוָּתֵר יַעֲקֹב לְבַדּוֹ", אָמַר רַבִּי אֶלְעָזָר: שְׁנִשְׁתַּיֵּיר עַל פַּכִּין קְטַנִּים, מִכָּאן לַצַּדִּיקִים שְׁחָבִיב עֲלֵיהֶם מָמוֹנָם יוֹתֵר מִגּוּפָם, וְכָל כָּךְ לָמָּה? לְפִי שֶׁאֵין פּוֹשְׁטִין יְדֵיהֶן בְּגָזֵל.

"And Yaakov was left alone." Rabbi Elazar said: He was left behind for the sake of small jugs. From here [we learn] that for the righteous, their money is dearer to them than their bodies. And why so much? Because they do not stretch out their hands to robbery.

"וַיֵּאָבֵק אִישׁ עִמּוֹ עַד עֲלוֹת הַשָּׁחַר", אָמַר רַבִּי יִצְחָק: מִכָּאן לְתַלְמִיד חָכָם שֶׁלֹּא יֵצֵא יְחִידִי בַּלַּיְלָה.

"And a man wrestled with him until the break of dawn." Rabbi Yitzchak said: From here [we learn] that a Torah scholar should not go out alone at night.

And here is the obvious question. One may not put oneself into a *makom sakanah*. A person alone at night, with no one around, is in danger—certainly in the Gemara's time, and in Yaakov's time too, from *shedim* and the like. The verse itself tells us what happened: when Yaakov was left alone, he wrestled all night with the *Sar shel Esav*, the angel the tradition identifies with Samael, Samech-Mem, who is the Satan, the *yetzer hara* and the angel of death in one (Bava Basra 16a). So Yaakov really did put himself in danger—for his property.

Rav Tzadok's point is that Yitzchak stood, for Avraham, in this same category: something more precious than his own life. If you think about it, our own children are an extension of who we are, our future generations. I would venture to say that they are more important to us than we are to ourselves—I think we can all agree. Yitzchak was on the same *madreigah* as one's wealth. And Yaakov's story shows the psychology: our assets can mean so much to us that we put ourselves into danger for them.

וְאַחַר כָּךְ נִסָּיוֹן הָעֲקֵדָה נִקְרָא וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶךָ

Afterward, the trial of the Akeidah was called "with all your might." (Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah 15)

III Yitzchak Was His World to Come

SOURCE *Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55 · Bereishis 22:2 · Midrash Tanchuma, Vayeira 22 · Tanchuma, Lech Lecha 3:3 · Bereishis Rabbah, Lech Lecha 44 · Shemos 32:32 · Kitzur Baal HaTurim, Shemos 27:20 · Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201*

The clearest statement of this idea is in the Beis Yaakov, the son of the Izhbitzer, on Parshas Vayeira. He opens with the principle: Avraham's surrender reached beyond everything we know.

> BEIS YAAKOV ON TORAH · VAYEIRA, OIS 55
>
> SURRENDER REACHING BEYOND WHAT IS KNOWN
>
> וְהַעִנְיָן בָּזֶה, כִּי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם הִנִּיחַ וְעָזַב כָּל חֶמְדַּת עוֹלָם הַזֶּה וְאַף חַיֵּי עוֹלָם הַבָּא בִּכְדֵי לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹן הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לַאֲתַר דְּלָא אִתְיְדַע,
>
> *The meaning is that Avraham Avinu, peace be upon him, set aside and relinquished everything desirable in this world, and even the life of the World to Come, in order to fulfill Hashem's will, reaching the realm that is not known.*
>
> וּפְעוּלָה כָּזוֹ הִגִּיעָה לְרוּם הַמַּעֲלוֹת עַד לְעַתִּיקָא קַדִּישָׁא.
>
> *Such an act reached the loftiest heights, as far as Atika Kadisha.*

Avraham Avinu set aside and relinquished everything desirable in this world, and even the life of the World to Come. Why? "To fulfill Hashem's will, reaching the realm that is not known." Such an act, the Beis Yaakov says, reached the loftiest heights, as far as *Atika Kadisha*. That is the *sefirah* of *Keser*, the *Keser Elyon*: the part that is not known, the very thought of Hashem, which we have no business trying to understand. It is the old question of why the world was created. We can never know what Hashem is thinking; we only know after the fact. Before anything existed there was this realm of the unknown, the realm of אֵין עוֹד מִלְּבַדּוֹ—"there is nothing besides Him." And that is how far Avraham was willing to go.

The Beis Yaakov continues, and here the Midrash Tanchuma becomes the proof: the first trial was like the last.

> BEIS YAAKOV · VAYEIRA, OIS 55 (CONTINUED)
>
> EVEN IF NOTHING WOULD REMAIN FOR HIMSELF
>
> וְאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָבַד לְהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ אַף בְּחַיֵּי עוֹלָם הַבָּא גַּם כֵּן, וְכָעִנְיָן דְּאִיתָא תַּנְחוּמָא לֶךְ ג׳ נְסָיוֹן הָרִאשׁוֹן כְּנֶסְיוֹן הָאַחֲרוֹן.
>
> *Avraham Avinu served Hashem with even the life of the World to Come as well, in keeping with what is stated in Tanchuma, Lech Lecha 3: The first trial was like the last trial.*
>
> נְסָיוֹן הָאַחֲרוֹן בְּלֶךְ לְךָ וְנְסָיוֹן הָרִאשׁוֹן בְּלֶךְ לְךָ,
>
> *The last trial was introduced with lech lecha, and the first trial was introduced with lech lecha.*

The first trial was *Lech lecha me'artzecha*, "Go forth from your land" (Bereishis 12:1); the last was *Lech lecha el eretz haMoriah*, "Go forth to the land of Moriah" (22:2). It is the same concept: a command to go, and a surrender of everything.

And what, in the end, did the Akeidah ask of him?

BEIS YAAKOV · VAYEIRA, OIS 55 (CONTINUED)

EVEN IF NOTHING WOULD REMAIN FOR HIMSELF

וּכְמוֹ שֶׁעָשָׂה בְּהָעֲקֵידָה שֶׁרָצָה לְהַקְרִיב בְּנוֹ יְחִידוֹ אֲשֶׁר אָהַבוֹ עוֹלָה כָּלִיל לַהַשֵּׁם, וְאַף שֶׁזֹּאת הִיא עִיקַּר עוֹלָם הַבָּא שֶׁלּוֹ, עִם כָּל זֶה רָצָה גַּם בָּזוֹ הַטּוֹבָה לַעֲבוֹד בִּפְעוּלַת הַשֵּׁם

As he did at the Akeidah, when he desired to offer his only son, whom he loved, as a complete burnt offering to Hashem, and although this was the very essence of his World to Come, nevertheless, he wished to devote even this good to Hashem's service,

וְאַף שֶׁלֹּא יִשָּׁאֵר לוֹ כְּלוּם. אַף כִּי אִיתָא רַבָּה לֶךְ מ״ד שֶׁהִבְטִיחַ לוֹ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא שְׂכָרְךָ מְתוּקָן לֶעָתִיד לָבֹא, אֲכָן אֵין נִרְאֶה זֹאת לָעַיִן וְלֹא נוֹדַע לָאָדָם.

even if nothing would remain for himself. Although it is stated in Bereishis Rabbah, Lech Lecha 44, that the Holy One, blessed be He, promised him, Your reward is prepared for the future, this is nevertheless not visible to the eye and is not known to the person.

Notice the Beis Yaakov's wording: "his only son, whom he loved." The Torah's word *yechidcha* distinguishes Yitzchak from Yishmael; Yitzchak was Avraham's one true son.

BEREISHIS 22:2

וַיֹּאמֶר קַח־נָא אֶת־בִּנְךָ אֶת־יְחִידְךָ אֲשֶׁר־אָהַבְתָּ אֶת־יִצְחָק וְלֶךְ־לְךָ אֶל־אֶרֶץ הַמֹּרִיָּה וְהַעֲלֵהוּ שָׁם לְעֹלָה עַל אַחַד הֶהָרִים אֲשֶׁר אֹמַר אֵלֶיךָ׃

And He said: Take, please, your son, your only one, whom you love, Yitzchak, and go to the land of Moriah, and bring him up there as an offering on one of the mountains that I will tell you.

The Midrash Tanchuma (Vayeira 22) shows how Hashem narrowed the command down, word by word, until only one name was left. Avraham's reply, "Is there a limit in the viscera?"—is there a measure to a father's love?—says everything about what was being asked.

MIDRASH TANCHUMA, VAYEIRA 22

קַח נָא אֶת בִּנְךָ. אָמַר לוֹ: אֵי זֶה בֵּן? אָמַר לוֹ: אֶת יְחִידְךָ. אָמַר לוֹ: זֶה יָחִיד לְאִמּוֹ וְזֶה יָחִיד לְאִמּוֹ. אָמַר לוֹ: אֲשֶׁר אָהַבְתָּ. אָמַר לוֹ: שְׁנֵיהֶם אֲנִי אוֹהֵב, אָמַר לוֹ: אֶת אֲשֶׁר אָהַבְתָּ הַרְבֵּה, אָמַר לוֹ: וְכִי יֵשׁ גְּבוּל בַּמֵּעַיִם? אָמַר לוֹ: אֶת יִצְחָק.

"Take, please, your son." [Avraham:] Which son? [Hashem:] Your only one. [Avraham:] This one is the only one of his mother, and that one is the only one of his mother. [Hashem:] Whom you love. [Avraham:] I love them both. [Hashem:] The one you love most. [Avraham:] Is there a limit in the viscera? [Hashem:] Yitzchak.

"And although this was the very essence of his World to Come." Olam Haba is the whole purpose: that is where a person is attached to the Shechinah, where there is no more *yetzer hara*, and where he can experience Hashem. That is basic *hashkafah*, as we all learned it. "Nevertheless, he wished to devote even this good to Hashem's service, even if nothing would remain for himself." The Beis Yaakov is saying it explicitly: Avraham was willing to give up even his Olam Haba in order to sacrifice his own

son, because that is what Hashem wanted. Even if logic says that I will lose my Olam Haba, if Hashem wants it, that is real *mesiras nefesh*.

Let us put that into perspective. Say you stand for something: you have a certain essence, a reason you were brought into the world, and you were taught a certain way. And then everything is turned a complete 180 degrees. (This is also part of what the Satan tries to do to Avraham, as we will see.) Real *mesiras nefesh* is not, "I will give my life for this because it is so important to me, and I will be rewarded in Olam Haba." Real *mesiras nefesh* means giving up your only asset, with no Olam Haba and nothing in the end. That is *mesiras nefesh*.

וְאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָבַד לְהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ אַף בְּחַיֵּי עוֹלָם הַבָּא גַּם כֵּן,

Avraham Avinu served Hashem with even the life of the World to Come as well. (Beis Yaakov, Vayeira 55)

Moshe Rabbeinu and Parshas Tetzaveh

SOURCE *Kitzur Baal HaTurim, Shemos 27:20 · Shemos 32:32 · Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201*

According to Rav Tzadok, we see the same idea in Moshe Rabbeinu. In the entire Torah, there is one *parashah* in which Moshe's name does not appear, during his lifetime: Parshas Tetzaveh. Why? The famous answer is that when Moshe said, "If not, erase me, please, from Your book that You have written" (Shemos 32:32), his words had to come to fruition. A sage's curse, even a conditional one, takes effect, and so his name is erased from that entire *parashah*. This is the Baal HaTurim.

> **KITZUR BAAL HATURIM, SHEMOS 27:20 · SHEMOS 32:32**
>
> **ואתה תצוה לא הזכיר משה בזה הסדר משא"כ בכל החומש שמשעה שנולד משה אין סדר שלא הוזכר בה (חוץ ממשנה תורה) והטעם משום שאמר מחני נא מספרך אשר כתבת וקללת חכם אפי' על תנאי באה ונתקיים בזה.**
>
> *"And you shall command"—Moshe is not mentioned in this parashah, unlike the rest of the Chumash, where from the time Moshe was born there is no parashah in which he is not mentioned (except Devarim). The reason: because he said, "Erase me, please, from Your book that You have written," and a sage's curse, even a conditional one, takes effect, and it was fulfilled here.*
>
> **וְעַתָּה אִם־תִּשָּׂא חַטָּאתָם וְאִם־אַיִן מְחֵנִי נָא מִסִּפְרְךָ אֲשֶׁר כָּתָבְתָּ**
>
> *And now, if You will bear their sin—and if not, erase me, please, from Your book that You have written.*

Rav Tzadok takes this to mean that Moshe reached the point where his own life did not matter if Klal Yisrael would not exist. In the *Tzidkas HaTzaddik* (201) he lists it among the things a person gives up out of love:

> **TZIDKAS HATZADDIK 201**
>
> וּכְדֶרֶךְ שֶׁאָמַר מֹשֶׁה רַבֵּינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם: "מְחֵנִי נָא מִסִּפְרְךָ אֲשֶׁר כָּתָבְתָּ" [שְׁמוֹת לב, לב] בִּשְׁבִיל אַהֲבַת יִשְׂרָאֵל
>
> *…and in the manner that Moshe Rabbeinu, peace be upon him, said, "Erase me, please, from Your book that You have written" (Shemos 32:32)—out of love for Yisrael.*

I would take it a step further: Moshe understood that he has no existence without Hashem in any case, and so he is willing, because it is not about his own ego but about what Hashem wants. **[source to be added: the speaker's own extension of this passage; Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201 itself grounds Moshe's request in love for Yisrael]**

This is a very big *avodah*. But it can also be a dangerous *avodah*, and we will see later why (Section VI), and what it means for us in practice.

IV Giving Up the World to Come

SOURCE *Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201 · Zohar, Terumah 66:670 · Pri Tzaddik, Shekalim 7:1 · Agra DeKalla, Beshalach 7 · Mei HaShiloach I, Vaeschanan 11 and Emor 9 · Bava Kamma 61a*

The Beis Yaakov speaks of giving up even Olam Haba. What does that mean concretely? To answer, we gather what the Izhbitz–Radzin tradition says about it, beginning with the *Tzidkas HaTzaddik*.

The Soul Itself

SOURCE *Tzidkas HaTzaddik 201 · Zohar, Terumah 66:670*

> **TZIDKAS HATZADDIK 201**
>
> מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ בִּשְׁבִיל אַהֲבַת הַשֵּׁם אֵינוֹ הַנֶּפֶשׁ לְבַד כִּפְשׁוּטָהּ אֶלָּא גַּם הַנְּשָׁמָה.
>
> *Mesiras nefesh out of love for Hashem does not mean one's life alone in the literal sense, but also the neshamah.*

Surrender for the love of Hashem does not mean the *nefesh* alone, in the literal sense, but the *neshamah* as well. Rav Tzadok explains, citing the Zohar (Terumah 66:670), that "with all your soul" includes *nefesh*, *ruach* and *neshamah*: the soul on all its levels. Even the soul itself: that is how far one is willing to go, to the point that it does not even exist anymore.

Avraham in the Furnace

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Shekalim 7:1 · Agra DeKalla, Beshalach 7 · Bereishis 9:5*

The Pri Tzaddik says it of Avraham himself:

PRI TZADDIK · PARSHAS SHEKALIM, MAAMAR 7

THE FURNACE

וְרַק מִפְּנֵי שֶׁבָּעֲרָה בּוֹ אַהֲבַת הַשֵּׁם מָסַר נַפְשׁוֹ וְנִשְׁמָתוֹ גַּם כֵּן וְאַף שֶׁיַּפְסִיד חֵס וְשָׁלוֹם חֶלְקוֹ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא מַה בְּכָךְ

It was only because love of Hashem burned within him that he surrendered his life and his soul as well, and even if, Heaven forbid, he should lose his portion in the World to Come, what of it?

כֵּיוָן שֶׁרָצוֹנוֹ שֶׁיִּתְקַדֵּשׁ שֵׁם שָׁמַיִם עַל יָדוֹ וְיִתְפָּרְסֵם אֱלֹהוּתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ שְׁמוֹ.

For his desire was that the Name of Heaven be sanctified through him, and that His Divinity, blessed be His Name, become known.

It was only because love of Hashem burned in him that Avraham surrendered both his *nefesh* and his *neshamah*. And even if, God forbid, he should lose his portion in the World to Come—"what of it?" His desire was that Hashem's Name be sanctified through him, and that His Divinity be made known.

EDITOR'S NOTE

In the shiur this passage was cited as "Bechukotai." It is the *maamar* for Parshas Shekalim (7:1). The collection reads these opening lines as describing the furnace of Ur Kasdim; the Akeidah begins at the words "But then he exercised the attribute of awe…," which we take up in Section VII.

The Bnei Yissaschar, in the *Agra DeKallah*, says the same about Avraham in Ur Kasdim, in the course of explaining Yosef's reasoning in the Midrash on Parshas Vayeishev:

AGRA DEKALLAH · BESHALACH 7

וְיוֹסֵף הָיָה סוֹבֵר דְּשָׁאנִי אַבְרָהָם דַּהֲרֵי מָסַר אֶת עַצְמוֹ עַל קִידּוּשׁ הַשֵּׁם, וְהוּא שֶׁלֹּא כְתוֹרָה לְבֶן נֹחַ דְּאֵינוֹ מְצוּוֶּה עַל קִידּוּשׁ הַשֵּׁם,

Yosef held that Avraham was different, for he had surrendered himself for Kiddush Hashem, which was not in accordance with the law of a descendant of Noach, who is not commanded in Kiddush Hashem,

וְאַדְרַבָּא מִתְחַיֵּיב בְּאַף דְּמָכֶם לְנַפְשׁוֹתֵיכֶם וְכוּלֵי בְּרֵאשִׁית ט׳ ה׳, אַף אַבְרָהָם בַּעֲבוּר קְדוּשַׁת שְׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ מָסַר אֶת עַצְמוֹ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא, כִּי הָיָה חוֹשֵׁב שֶׁיֵּעָנֵשׁ בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא עַל מְסִירוּת נַפְשׁוֹ,

and, on the contrary, incurs liability under But your blood, of your lives, and so forth, Bereishis 9:5. Yet Avraham, for the sanctification of His blessed Name, surrendered himself in this world and in the World to Come, for he thought that he would be punished in the World to Come for surrendering his life.

וְאַף עַל פִּי כֵן הִשְׁלִיךְ אֶת נַפְשׁוֹ מִנֶּגֶד עֲבוּר אַהֲבָתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ שְׁמוֹ כַּאֲשֶׁר כָּתַבְנוּ בִּמְקוֹמוֹ, וְאִם כֵּן דִּין הוּא שֶׁיֵּצֵא מִכְּלַל בֶּן נֹחַ לְגַמְרֵי, מַה שֶּׁאֵין כֵּן הַבָּנִים, וְהָבֵן.

Nevertheless, he cast his life aside out of love for Him, blessed be His Name, as we explained in its place. If so, it is fitting that he should leave the status of a descendant of Noach entirely, unlike the children; understand this.

Yosef held that Avraham was different from the other descendants of Noach. A descendant of Noach is not commanded in *kiddush Hashem*; on the contrary, he is liable: "But your blood, of your lives, I shall demand" (Bereishis 9:5). Avraham, however, for the sanctification of His Name, surrendered this world and the next. He thought that he would be punished in the World to Come for surrendering his life, and nevertheless he cast his life aside out of love. It is therefore fitting that he leave the status of Noach's descendants entirely. This passage speaks of the furnace, and it says expressly that Avraham accepted even the prospect of punishment in Olam Haba. **[source to be added: the Tosafos on kiddush Hashem for bnei Noach, which the shiur mentioned as cited in the Pri Tzaddik on Lech Lecha]**

The Qualification: Before One's Portion Is Clarified

SOURCE *Mei HaShiloach I, Vaeschanan 11 · Devarim 6:5*

The Izhbitzer, whose teachings Rav Tzadok expands upon, says this explicitly. In the Shema, the first paragraph says "with all your might." In the second paragraph, *Vehayah im shamoa*, those words do not appear.

> **MEI HASHILOACH I · VAESCHANAN 11**
>
> וּבְפָרָשַׁת וְהָיָה אִם שָׁמֹעַ לֹא נֶאֱמַר וּבְכָל מְאֹדֶיכֶם, כִּי מְאֹדְךָ הַיְינוּ מְאֹד מְאֹד לִמְסוֹר אֶת נַפְשׁוֹ עַל קִדֻּשַׁת שְׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ, הַיְינוּ לִמְסוֹר נַפְשׁוֹ אַף בְּחַיֵּי עוֹלָם הַבָּא;
>
> *In the paragraph Vehayah im shamoa, it does not say with all your might, for meodecha means an exceedingly great surrender of one's soul for the sanctification of His blessed Name, meaning to surrender oneself even with respect to life in the World to Come.*
>
> וְזֶהוּ רַק קוֹדֶם שֶׁיִּתְבָּרֵר לָאָדָם חֶלְקוֹ הַשַּׁיָּךְ לוֹ בְּשָׁרְשׁוֹ, כִּי לְכָל נֶפֶשׁ שַׁיָּךְ מִצְוָה מְיוּחֶדֶת שֶׁעַל יָדָהּ יַגִּיעַ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא כְּפִי הַמִּצְוָה וּכְפִי אֲשֶׁר יְקַיְּמֶהָ, וְזֶה עִיקָּר לְכָל נֶפֶשׁ; וְקוֹדֶם שֶׁנִּתְבָּרֵר לָאָדָם חֶלְקוֹ צָרִיךְ לַעֲבוֹד אֶת הַשֵּׁם בְּזֶה הָאוֹפָן
>
> *This applies only before the portion belonging to a person at his root has become clear to him, for to every soul there belongs a particular mitzvah through which that soul will attain the World to Come, according to the mitzvah and the manner in which he fulfills it, and this is fundamental for each soul. Before his portion has become clear to him, a person must serve Hashem in this manner:*
>
> שֶׁלֹּא יִמְצָא אֶצְלוֹ דָּבָר שֶׁלֹּא יוּכַל לְמָסְרָהּ עַל קִדּוּשׁ הַשֵּׁם; אַךְ אַחַר שֶׁיִּבּוֹרַר לָאָדָם חֶלְקוֹ לֹא יַחְפּוֹץ הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ מִן הָאָדָם שֶׁיַּעֲבוֹד אוֹתוֹ בְּזֶה הָאוֹפָן, כִּי לֹא יִרְצֶה הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לִיקַּח מִן הָאָדָם מַה שֶּׁסִּיגֵּל;
>
> *that there be nothing in his possession which he would be unable to surrender for Kiddush Hashem. But after a person's portion has been clarified, Hashem does not desire that he serve Him in this manner, for Hashem does not wish to take from a person what he has acquired.*

Me'odecha, says the Izhbitzer, means surrendering one's soul for the sanctity of His Name—even with respect to life in the World to Come. But this applies only before a person's portion, the portion that belongs to his root, has become clear to him. Every soul has a particular *mitzvah* through which it will attain its Olam Haba, according to that *mitzvah* and how it is fulfilled, and that is fundamental for each soul. Before the portion is clear, one must serve Hashem in this way, so that nothing in his possession is something he could not surrender for the sanctity of Hashem. But once a person's portion has been

clarified, Hashem does not want him to serve in this manner, "for Hashem does not wish to take from a person what he has acquired."

A Loss That Will Be Restored

SOURCE *Mei HaShiloach I, Emor 9 · Bava Kamma 61a*

In Parshas Emor the Izhbitzer speaks about the *aravah*, the willow, one of the four *minim* that we take on Sukkos. The willow has no taste and no fragrance. It corresponds, he says, to the depth of evil.

> **MEI HASHILOACH I · EMOR 9**
>
> עַרְבֵי נַחַל הוּא נֶגֶד עוֹמֶק רַע, כִּי אֵין בָּהּ לֹא טַעַם וְלֹא רֵיחַ; וְהָעִנְיָן בָּזֶה כִּדְאִיתָא בַּגְּמָרָא:
>
> *The willows of the brook correspond to the depth of evil, for the willow has neither taste nor fragrance. The meaning is as stated in the Gemara:*
>
> כָּל הַמּוֹסֵר נַפְשׁוֹ לָמוּת עַל דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה אֵין אוֹמְרִים דָּבָר הֲלָכָה מִשְּׁמוֹ, בָּבָא קַמָּא דַּף ס״א. וְנִרְאֶה שֶׁמִּזֶּה הַמַּעֲשֶׂה לֹא יַגִּיעַ לְהָאָדָם שׁוּם הֲנָאָה לֹא בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וְלֹא בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא; אַךְ בְּהָאֲגוּדָּה מֵהַצּוֹרֶךְ גַּם עֲרָבָה לְהִמָּצֵא, כִּי אֲגוּדָּה רוֹמֵז עַל שְׁלֵימוּת הָאָדָם,
>
> *Whoever gives himself over to die for words of Torah, a halachic teaching is not stated in his name. Bava Kamma 61a. It appears that from this act no benefit will reach the person, either in this world or in the World to Come. Yet the willow, too, must be present in the bundle, for the bundle alludes to the completeness of the person.*
>
> וּבִשְׁלֵימוּת הָאָדָם צָרִיךְ לְהִמָּצֵא גַּם הַכֹּחַ הַזֶּה שֶׁיּוּכַל לִמְסוֹר נַפְשׁוֹ לָמוּת אַף שֶׁלֹּא יַגִּיעַ לוֹ הֲנָאָה אַף לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא; וּבְאִם יִמָּצֵא בָּאָדָם זֶה הַכֹּחַ אָז יַשִּׂיג גַּם שְׁאָר הָעוֹמְקִים בִּשְׁלֵימוּת, וְעַל יְדֵי זֶה יִקָּרֵא עוֹמֶק, לְפִי שֶׁגַּם בְּהָרַע יִמָּצֵא טוֹב
>
> *For the person's completeness, this capacity must also be present: that he be able to surrender his life unto death even if no benefit will reach him, even in the World to Come. If this capacity is present in a person, he will then attain the other depths in their completeness as well. Through this it is called a depth, because good will be found even within the evil,*
>
> וְהִיא שֶׁלָּעָתִיד יַחֲזוֹר הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ לְכָל מִי שֶׁהִפְסִיד בִּמְסִירוּת נַפְשׁוֹ עַל דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה.
>
> *namely, that in the future Hashem will restore to everyone what he lost through surrendering his life for words of Torah.*

The Gemara he refers to is in Bava Kamma (61a), which records a tradition received from the court of Shmuel of Ramah: whoever gives himself over to die for words of Torah, a halachic teaching is not stated in his name. This act, then, brings a person no benefit in this world or in the World to Come. Yet the willow must be present in the bundle, for the bundle alludes to the wholeness of a person, and in his wholeness this capacity must also be present: that he be able to give up his life even if he will not benefit, even in the World to Come. And if a person has this strength, he will reach the other depths in their completeness as well.

That is why it is called a depth: for good will be found even within the evil. "In the future Hashem will restore to everyone what he lost through surrendering his life for words of Torah." It is a great loss to be *moser nefesh*. A person may even lose his Olam Haba. But, the Izhbitzer says, ultimately it will not be lost.

V “Even on That Condition”

SOURCE *Bereishis Rabbah 56:4 · Midrash Tanchuma, Vayeira 22 · Pri Tzaddik, Kedushas Shabbos, maamar 4, ¶9 · Nazir 23b · Yevamos 90b · Rambam, Hilchos Yesodei HaTorah 9:3 · Temurah 14b · Pri Tzaddik, Lag BaOmer 1*

Now we come to the Akeidah itself, and to what Avraham was willing to give up. Rav Tzadok builds on a Midrash in which Samael confronts Avraham before the Akeidah.

Samael Comes to Avraham

SOURCE *Bereishis Rabbah 56:4*

BEREISHIS RABBAH 56:4 · SAMAEL AND AVRAHAM

בָּא לוֹ סַמָּאֵ״ל אֶצֶל אַבִינוּ אַבְרָהָם אָמַר לֵיהּ סָבָא סָבָא אוֹבַדְתְּ לִבָּךְ, בֵּן שֶׁנִּתַּן לְךָ לְמֵאָה שָׁנָה אַתָּה הוֹלֵךְ לִשְׁחֲטוֹ, אָמַר לוֹ עַל מְנָת כֵּן.

Samael came to Avraham Avinu and said to him: Old man, old man, have you lost your mind? A son who was given to you at a hundred years old—you are going to slaughter him? He said to him: Even on that condition.

אָמַר לוֹ וְאִם מְנַסֶּה אוֹתְךָ יוֹתֵר מִכֵּן אַתְּ יָכוֹל לַעֲמֹד, [איוב ד, ב]: הֲנִסָּה דָבָר אֵלֶיךָ תִּלְאֶה, אָמַר לוֹ וְיֶתֶר עַל דֵּין.

He said to him: And if He tests you with more than this, can you stand it? [Iyov 4:2] “Shall one venture a word to you—will you be weary?” He said to him: And more than this.

אָמַר לוֹ לְמָחָר אוֹמֵר לְךָ שׁוֹפֵךְ דָּם אַתְּ חַיָּב שֶׁשִּׁשְׁפַּכְתְּ דָּמוֹ שֶׁל בִּנְךָ,

He said to him: Tomorrow He will say to you, You are a shedder of blood; you are liable for having shed your son’s blood.

אָמַר לוֹ, עַל מְנָת כֵּן.

Avraham answered him: Even on that condition.

וְכֵיוָן שֶׁלֹּא הוֹעִיל מִמֶּנּוּ כְּלוּם בָּא לוֹ אֵצֶל יִצְחָק, אָמַר לוֹ בְּרָא דַּעֲלוּבְתָּא, הוֹלֵךְ הוּא לְשָׁחְטָךְ, אָמַר לוֹ עַל מְנָת כֵּן.

And when nothing availed with him, he came to Yitzchak and said to him: Son of the unfortunate woman! He is going to slaughter you. He said to him: Even on that condition.

The phrase *al menas ken*, “on that condition,” is the heart of this Midrash. Samael tells Avraham what will happen to him: tomorrow you will be called a shedder of blood, liable for your son’s blood. And Avraham’s answer is the same each time: even on that condition. Even if I am liable. Even if it costs more. Even so.

The Midrash Tanchuma (Vayeira 22) tells the rest of the story. The Satan appears to Avraham on the road as an old man and tries to turn him back. Avraham answers: it was not a seducer who told me what to do, but the Holy One, blessed be He. Then the Satan comes to Yitzchak. Yitzchak is going “to study Torah”—“in your life, or in your death?”—and he answers, “Even so, I will not transgress the will of my Maker and the command of my father.” And when none of this works, the Satan makes a great river in their path. The water reaches Avraham’s neck, and he cries out that the waters have come “up to the soul.” Hashem rebukes the spring, and the river dries up. This is the battle with the Satan, in the Midrash, that I mentioned.

MIDRASH TANCHUMA, VAYEIRA 22 · FRAGMENTS

לֹא מַשְׂטִין הָיָה אֶלָּא הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא

It was not a seducer, but the Holy One, blessed be He. (Avraham, to the Satan)

לִלְמֹד תּוֹרָה… בְּחַיֶּיךָ אוֹ בְּמִיתָתְךָ… עָלוּב בַּר עָלוּבָה

To study Torah… In your life, or in your death?… Wretched son of a wretched mother. (The Satan and Yitzchak)

אַף עַל פִּי כֵן לֹא אֶעֱבֹר עַל דַּעַת יוֹצְרִי וְעַל צִוּוּי אָבִי

Even so, I will not transgress the will of my Maker and the command of my father. (Yitzchak)

וְנַעֲשָׂה לִפְנֵיהֶם נָהָר גָּדוֹל… הִגִּיעוּ הַמַּיִם עַד צַוָּארוֹ…

And a great river was made before them… the water reached his neck…

וְעַכְשָׁו בָּאוּ מַיִם עַד נָפֶשׁ [תהלים סט, ב]… מִיָּד גָּעַר הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא אֶת הַמַּעְיָן וְיָבֵשׁ הַנָּהָר

And now the waters have come up to the soul [Tehillim 69:2]… Immediately the Holy One, blessed be He, rebuked the spring, and the river dried up.

Rav Tzadok: "Even on That Condition"

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Sefer Kedushas Shabbos, maamar 4, paragraph 9 · Nazir 23b*

Rav Tzadok takes up this Midrash in the Pri Tzaddik on Shabbos.

PRI TZADDIK · SEFER KEDUSHAS SHABBOS, MAAMAR 4, PARAGRAPH 9

וְהוּא הֵשִׁיב עַל מְנָת כֵּן, דְּמִכָּל מָקוֹם כַּוָּנָתוֹ לְשֵׁם שָׁמַיִם וְעוֹשֶׂה עֲבֵירָה לִשְׁמָהּ. וַאֲפִילּוּ יִהְיֶה אֱמֶת שֶׁיֵּעָנֵשׁ אַחַר כָּךְ עַל זֶה.

And he answered: Even on that condition, for in any event his intention is for the sake of Heaven, and he acts in the manner of a transgression undertaken for Heaven's sake. Even if it should be true that he will afterward be punished for this,

הוּא רוֹצֶה רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת כָּל מַעֲשָׂיו לְשֵׁם שָׁמַיִם וְלֹא לְקַבָּלַת שָׂכָר. וַאֲפִילּוּ יֵעָנֵשׁ עַל זֶה הוּא מִתְכַּוֵּין לַעֲשׂוֹת נַחַת רוּחַ לְפָנָיו מַה שֶּׁאֵין כֵּן בְּהֵיפֶךְ כַּוָּנָתוֹ לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ.

he desires only to perform all his actions for the sake of Heaven, without seeking to receive reward. Even if he should be punished for it, his intention is to bring Him nachas ruach, whereas, in taking the opposite course, his intention would be directed toward his love for his son.

Rav Tzadok is being *medayek* in the words *al menas ken*. Avraham answers the Satan, "even on that condition," because in any event his intention is for the sake of Heaven, and he acts in the manner of an *aveirah lishmah*, a transgression done for Heaven's sake. (The Gemara says that such a transgression is greater than a *mitzvah* performed without that intention: Nazir 23b.) As I read it, Rav Tzadok is learning that Hashem is telling Avraham to do an *aveirah*. An *aveirah* brings punishment; that is why the Satan warns him, "You will be a murderer; you will be liable." And Avraham says: even if it is true that I will be punished afterward for this, I want only to do all my actions for the sake of Heaven, without seeking to receive reward. Even if I am punished, my intention is to give Hashem *nachas ruach*. Whereas if I took the opposite course, my intention would be directed toward my love for my son. That is how Rav Tzadok reads *al menas ken*.

FROM THE ROOM · DOES HE LOSE ALL OF OLAM HABA?

Comment: It cannot mean that he loses his entire Olam Haba. At most he loses some of it. Avraham was a *tzaddik*, and he still receives reward for what he did.

Response: Perhaps. But the test was whether he would act with no reward in view, neither in this world nor in the next. That is the highest level: if it means that I lose everything, and Hashem wants it, then it is not about me and not about my ego, and I am willing.

Comment: And probably Hashem gave him his Olam Haba anyway, in reward for going to such lengths to do what He wanted.

Can Hashem Command an Aveirah?

SOURCE *Yevamos 90b · Rambam, Hilchos Yesodei HaTorah 9:3 · Temurah 14b*

This is where the room joined in, and the discussion is worth recording.

FROM THE ROOM · THE NAVI AND THE HORA'AS SHA'AH

Question: How can Hashem command a person to break the Torah—actively, and not merely by sitting passively (*shev ve'al ta'aseh*)?

Response: There are times when a *navi* tells us to break the Torah: Eliyahu on Har HaCarmel. And the Oral Torah itself was written down, though it was not supposed to be: "It is a time to act for Hashem; they have voided Your Torah." But these are *hora'os sha'ah*, temporary rulings, not permanent ones. The Akeidah is the ultimate *hora'as sha'ah*. A *hora'as sha'ah* means that we do not understand, and we do what we are told.

Comment: And we are told in the Torah to listen to His representative; one who does not listen is liable to death. A *navi* who has proven himself is not asking us to violate the Torah. If God is telling you to do something, it is now a *mitzvah*. So what is the hold-up?

Response: In that moment Avraham is working in the world of *asiyah*, where we have doubts. He had three days to think about it. He fought the Satan, according to the Midrash, even through the river, to get there. And when he reached the place and took the knife, he heard: "Avraham, Avraham."

Comment: But the command was only "bring him up." It was Avraham who understood it as slaughter.

Response: Fine. He understood "bring him up" as slaughter, and he acted on it. (We return to this in Section VIII, with Rashi.)

The sources behind this discussion are the Gemara in Yevamos and the Rambam:

YEVAMOS 90B · RAMBAM, HILCHOS YESODEI HATORAH 9:3

תָּא שְׁמַע: ״אֵלָיו תִּשְׁמָעוּן״ — אֲפִילּוּ אוֹמֵר לְךָ: עֲבוֹר עַל אַחַת מִכָּל מִצְוֹת שֶׁבַּתּוֹרָה, כְּגוֹן אֵלִיָּהוּ בְּהַר הַכַּרְמֶל, הַכֹּל לְפִי שָׁעָה — שְׁמַע לוֹ.

Come and hear: "To him you shall listen" (Devarim 18:15)—even if he tells you to transgress one of all the commandments in the Torah, as Eliyahu did on Har HaCarmel, entirely for the moment—listen to him.

וְכֵן אִם יֹאמַר לָנוּ הַנָּבִיא שֶׁנּוֹדָע לָנוּ שֶׁהוּא נָבִיא לַעֲבֹר עַל אַחַת מִכָּל מִצְוֹת הָאֲמוּרוֹת בַּתּוֹרָה אוֹ עַל מִצְוֹת הַרְבֵּה בֵּין קַלּוֹת בֵּין חֲמוּרוֹת לְפִי שָׁעָה מִצְוָה לִשְׁמֹעַ לוֹ.

And likewise, if the prophet whom we know to be a prophet tells us to transgress one of the commandments stated in the Torah, or many commandments, whether light or severe, for the moment—it is a mitzvah to listen to him. (The Rambam excludes idolatry.)

TEMURAH 14B · GITTIN 60B · TEHILLIM 119:126

כּוֹתְבֵי הֲלָכוֹת כְּשׂוֹרְפֵי תּוֹרָה.

Rabbi Yochanan said: Those who write down halachos are like those who burn the Torah.

דְּבָרִים שֶׁעַל פֶּה אִי אַתָּה רַשַּׁאי לְאוֹמְרָן בִּכְתָב.

Matters of the Oral Torah you are not permitted to say in writing.

אָמְרִי: דִּלְמָא מִילְּתָא חַדְתָּא שָׁאנֵי, דְּהָא רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן וְרֵישׁ לָקִישׁ מְעַיְּינִי בְּסִיפְרָא דְּאַגָּדְתָּא בְּשַׁבְּתָא, וְדָרְשִׁי הָכִי: ״עֵת לַעֲשׂוֹת לַה׳ הֵפֵרוּ תּוֹרָתֶךָ״, אָמְרִי: מוּטָב תֵּיעָקֵר תּוֹרָה, וְאַל תִּשְׁתַּכַּח תּוֹרָה מִיִּשְׂרָאֵל.

They said: Perhaps a new matter is different, for Rabbi Yochanan and Reish Lakish would study the Book of Aggadah on Shabbos, and they expounded as follows: "It is a time to act for Hashem; they have voided Your Torah" (Tehillim 119:126). They said: It is better that [this] Torah be uprooted than that Torah be forgotten from Yisrael.

FROM THE ROOM · IS IT EVEN AN AVEIRAH?

Comment: But is it an *aveirah*? Hashem forbids *shaatnez* and commands *tzitzis*; He forbids marrying a brother's wife and commands *yibum*. We see this constantly in the Torah. It is an *aveirah* only if it is done at the wrong time. When Hashem tells you to do it, it is a *mitzvah*. The same with Amalek and the seven nations: a commanded war, a *milchemes mitzvah*.

Comment: And Avraham was a *navi*, hearing it directly from God. For him it would have been an *aveirah* not to do it. So Rav Tzadok's premise is false. He is setting up a straw man.

Response: Ultimately, yes, it is a *mitzvah*, because Hashem commanded it. But there is also a psychological layer here, and it is about the ego: what I want versus what Hashem wants.

Adam and Avraham

SOURCE *Bereishis 2:17 · Bereishis 22*

That is the contrast between Adam HaRishon and Avraham. Adam was given one simple command: do not eat from the *Eitz HaDa'as*. He thought: this cannot be the whole purpose of my existence; there must be something bigger here; perhaps He wants me to commit an *aveirah*. I recall Rav Dessler saying that Adam reasoned that it would be better if he sinned, because from *teshuvah*, from finding Hashem out of that place, one truly experiences Hashem. **[source to be added: the speaker's recollection of Rav Dessler on Adam HaRishon]** Adam did the exact opposite of Avraham: he overthought, and he was punished. Avraham never made it about himself. He did not overthink. He stayed on script: if this is what Hashem wants, I will do it.

FROM THE ROOM · ADAM, CHAVA AND THE SATAN

Comment: In Adam's case, Hashem gave a command and that was the end of it. Then his wife said, "I ate, and I did not die," and now he had proof. He could rationalize all he wanted, and that is what he did.

Comment: Avraham had no Chava showing him why he could get away with it. He had a Satan talking to him instead, but the Satan was not showing why it would be bad to disobey. In the end it was a direct command of Hashem.

Response: And notice that Avraham does not argue with the Satan. Adam and Chava argued, and they went back and forth, and they were pushed. Avraham just says: even so, I will do it. The Satan threatens him constantly, and he does not give in. We too get sucked into arguments on the other side's terms. Avraham says: no.

What Exactly Does Rav Tzadok Say?

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Kedushas Shabbos, maamar 4, paragraph 9*

FROM THE ROOM · AM I READING RAV TZADOK CORRECTLY?

Question: Rav Tzadok says it is an *aveirah lishmah*. Am I reading him correctly, or incorrectly?

Comment: I think you are misreading him. Samael is arguing with Avraham: if you do this, you will not be a *tzaddik*; it is your son; it contradicts the promises. And Avraham answers: I heard directly from the Ribono shel Olam. So even if you are right, Samael, Hashem told me. Rav Tzadok is putting those words into Avraham's mouth. That is what Avraham says to the Satan. It is not Rav Tzadok's own position that this is an *aveirah*.

Response: But Rav Tzadok himself says *aveirah lishmah*, and he says, "he desires only to perform all his actions for the sake of Heaven, without seeking to receive reward."

Comment: Yes, and that is the point: even if he is punished, he is not doing it for reward. "I do not care about reward; I do not care about punishment; Hashem told me." Rav Tzadok is not *mechadesh* here that one may do an *aveirah lishmah*. In other places he says that, with Shimshon, with Zimri. **[source to be added: Rav Tzadok on aveirah lishmah in the cases of Shimshon and Zimri, mentioned in the room]** Here, he is saying what Avraham would answer.

Response: Fine. I hear you. On the key point we agree: Avraham seeks no reward, even if he will be punished.

AN ASIDE: WHOSE TORAH?

The disagreement made me think of a teaching of Rav Tzadok in the Pri Tzaddik for Lag BaOmer (Lag BaOmer 1). We celebrate the *hilula* of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai on the day of his passing. But the root of the Oral Torah is Rabbi Akiva, and Rabbi Shimon was his student. Why, then, do we not celebrate Rabbi Akiva? Because, Rav Tzadok says, one cannot establish a day of celebration on the day of one who was killed: ולא יכלו לקבוע יום הלולא ביום פטירת ר״ע מפני שנהרג ("they could not establish the day of the *hilula* on the day of Rabbi Akiva's passing, because he was killed"). So why is it called the *hilula* of Rabbi Shimon, when his Torah is still Rabbi Akiva's?

Rav Tzadok's answer is a beautiful idea. While your Rebbe is alive, everything you receive from him is your Rebbe's Torah. Once he has departed, it becomes yours, and you explain it in your own way: וביום שנסתלק אז נקבעו הד״ת בלבב ישראל תלמודיו ("and on the day he departed, the words of Torah were fixed in the hearts of Yisrael, his students"). So it is Rabbi Akiva's Torah, but the way Rabbi Shimon explains it is his own.

The same is true of us. Rav Tzadok has been gone for generations, yet we learn the same words through our own lenses. You have the right to read Rav Tzadok your way, just as I read him mine: אֵלּוּ וְאֵלּוּ דִּבְרֵי אֱלֹהִים חַיִּים הֵן, "these and these are the words of the living God."

VI Without a Prize

SOURCE *Avos 1:3 · Avos DeRabbi Nosson 5 · Avos 4:2 · Rambam, Introduction to Perek Chelek · Sifrei, Devarim 41 · Beis Yaakov on Torah, Toldos, ois 24 · Kedushas Levi, Vayeitzei 26 · Megillah 13b*

One idea has run through everything so far: serving Hashem with no reward in view. It is not a Chassidic invention. It is a teaching of the Mishnah, in the name of one of the earliest Sages.

AVOS 1:3 · ANTIGONUS OF SOCHO

אַנְטִיגְנוֹס אִישׁ סוֹכוֹ קִבֵּל מִשִּׁמְעוֹן הַצַּדִּיק. הוּא הָיָה אוֹמֵר, אַל תִּהְיוּ כַּעֲבָדִים הַמְשַׁמְּשִׁין אֶת הָרַב עַל מְנָת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס, אֶלָּא הֱוּוּ כַּעֲבָדִים הַמְשַׁמְּשִׁין אֶת הָרַב שֶׁלֹּא עַל מְנָת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס, וִיהִי מוֹרָא שָׁמַיִם עֲלֵיכֶם.

Antigonus of Socho received [the tradition] from Shimon HaTzaddik. He used to say: Do not be like servants who serve the master in order to receive a reward; rather, be like servants who serve the master not in order to receive a reward—and let the fear of Heaven be upon you.

Serve Hashem, in other words, because He is your Master, and not for what you will collect from Him. But this teaching carries a danger, and Avos DeRabbi Nosson (chapter 5) records what became of it. Antigonus had two disciples, who taught his words to their own students, and those students to theirs. In time some of them stopped to examine the saying. Had our fathers known, they reasoned, that there is another world and a resurrection of the dead, they would never have said such a thing. The Midrash gives their argument, and tells how it ended:

AVOS DERABBI NOSSON 5

אפשר שיעשה פועל מלאכה כל היום ולא יטול שכרו ערבית

…Is it possible that a laborer works all day and does not take his wages in the evening?…

עמדו ופירשו מן התורה ונפרצו מהם שתי פרצות צדוקין וביתוסין

They arose and separated themselves from the Torah, and two breaches burst out from them: the Tzedukim and the Baisusim.

Hebrew as printed in the Vilna edition, unvocalized; the passage is abridged to the two lines quoted.

The students were wrong, of course. We do have reward and punishment (*sachar v'onesh*), and the Torah is full of both. But their challenge points to a real difficulty. If we are meant to serve Hashem without looking for a reward, why did He build reward and punishment into the world at all?

Why Is There Reward at All?

SOURCE *Avos 4:2 · Rambam, Introduction to Perek Chelek · Sifrei, Devarim 41*

There are two answers. The first is that the reward is not a payment from outside. The *mitzvah* itself is the reward: a natural cause and effect, like medicine. Medicine helps whether or not the patient understands why. The *mitzvos* work on us in the same way, physically and spiritually, and the whole Torah is a regimen for serving Hashem. This is close to Ben Azzai's teaching in Pirkei Avos:

AVOS 4:2 · BEN AZZAI

בֶּן עַזַּאי אוֹמֵר, הֱוֵי רָץ לְמִצְוָה קַלָּה כְּבַחֲמוּרָה, וּבוֹרֵחַ מִן הָעֲבֵרָה. שֶׁמִּצְוָה גּוֹרֶרֶת מִצְוָה, וַעֲבֵרָה גּוֹרֶרֶת עֲבֵרָה. שֶׂשְּׂכַר מִצְוָה, מִצְוָה. וּשְׂכַר עֲבֵרָה, עֲבֵרָה

Ben Azzai says: Run to a light mitzvah as to a severe one, and flee from an aveirah. For one mitzvah draws another mitzvah, and one aveirah draws another aveirah. For the reward of a mitzvah is a mitzvah, and the reward of an aveirah is an aveirah.

The second answer is the Rambam's. In his Introduction to Perek Chelek (his Commentary on the Mishnah, Sanhedrin chapter 10), where he also sets out the Thirteen Principles, he asks this very question, and he answers with a child. A young boy is brought to a teacher, but he cannot yet grasp the worth of learning, so the teacher coaxes him: Read, and I will give you nuts or figs. As the boy grows, nuts no longer move him, and the teacher offers fine shoes or clothes; later a coin or two; later honor and position. Each prize is beneath the learning it serves, says the Rambam, and yet it is necessary, because of the smallness of a child's mind.

So too, he explains, the Torah and the Sages speak to us of reward and punishment, to carry people step by step toward serving Hashem for the truth's own sake. The highest level is Avraham Avinu's: he served from love (Sotah 31a). The Sages therefore allowed ordinary people to keep the commandments in hope of reward and fear of punishment, until they come to grasp the truth, and they faulted Antigonus for stating the higher teaching so openly to everyone: "Sages, be careful with your words" (Avos 1:11). Nothing is lost for the masses, the Rambam adds, because from "not for its own sake" one comes to "for its own sake" (see Pesachim 50b).

We know this pattern from our own homes. Parents use the carrot and the stick, and the child does not appreciate each reward until he realizes what the bigger picture is: I love Mommy and Tatty, and I want to help them. Once he appreciates that, he no longer needs the carrot.

The Sifrei says the same in so many words, on the verse "to love Hashem your God" (Devarim 11:13):

SIFREI, DEVARIM 41 · "TO LOVE HASHEM YOUR GOD"

שֶׁמָּא תֹּאמַר: הֲרֵינִי לוֹמֵד תּוֹרָה בִּשְׁבִיל שֶׁאֵעָשֵׁיר, בִּשְׁבִיל שֶׁאֶקָּרֵא רַבִּי, בִּשְׁבִיל שֶׁאֶקַּבֵּל שָׂכָר לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא? תַּלְמוּד לוֹמַר: לְאַהֲבָה אֶת ה׳ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם, כָּל שֶׁאַתֶּם עוֹשִׂים – לֹא תְהוּ עוֹשִׂים אֶלָּא מֵאַהֲבָה.

Perhaps you will say: I will study Torah in order to become rich, in order to be called Rabbi, in order to receive reward in the World to Come? The verse says: "To love Hashem your God"—whatever you do, do only out of love.

The Beis Yaakov takes the same thought to its edge. In Parshas Toldos he describes how Esav presented himself to Yitzchak, through his question about tithing salt, and in the course of that description he states a greater *avodah*:

BEIS YAAKOV ON TORAH · TOLDOS, OIS 24, PARAGRAPH 1

כִּי יֵשׁ גַּם עֲבוֹדָה גְּדוֹלָה מִזּוּ שֶׁהָאָדָם מוֹסֵר נַפְשׁוֹ בְּמְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וּבָעוֹלָם הַבָּא בִּשְׁבִיל כְּבוֹד שָׁמַיִם, כִּי גַּם כַּוָּנָה לִשְׂכַּר בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא הוּא גַּם כֵּן לְגַרְמֵיהּ;

For there is also a greater form of service than this: that a person surrenders himself through mesiras nefesh in this world and in the World to Come for the honor of Heaven. For even an intention directed toward the reward of the World to Come is also for oneself.

Beis Yaakov states this spiritual ideal while explaining what Esav sought to convey through his question about tithing salt. The surrounding argument describes Esav's deceptive presentation to Yitzchak; it does not establish that Esav truly attained this avodah.

That is the tricky part. Even the hope of Olam Haba can be a way of serving oneself. So we have to ask ourselves honestly: are we doing our *avodah al menas lekabel pras*, in order to receive a prize?

Rochel and the Signs

SOURCE *Kedushas Levi, Bereishis, Vayeitzei 26 · Megillah 13b*

The Kedushas Levi states the principle outright and illustrates it with Rochel. First, the story, from the Gemara in Megillah (13b). Yaakov had given Rochel signs by which he would know her, for Lavan was a swindler and would not marry off the younger daughter before the elder. When the wedding night came, Rochel thought: "Now my sister will be put to shame," and she gave the signs to Leah.

MEGILLAH 13B

כִּי מְטָא לֵילְיָא, אֲמַרָה: הַשְׁתָּא מִיכַּסְפָא אֲחָתַאי. מְסָרַתִינְהוּ נִיהֲלַהּ.

When the night arrived, she said: Now my sister will be put to shame. She gave them to her.

The preceding line of the Gemara tells that Yaakov had given Rochel the signs.

KEDUSHAS LEVI · BEREISHIS, VAYEITZEI 26

הַכְּלָל הוּא שֶׁאָדָם צָרִיךְ לַעֲבוֹד אֶת הַבּוֹרֵא בָּרוּךְ הוּא לֹא בִּשְׁבִיל שׁוּם קַבָּלַת שָׂכָר כְּלָל וְיִמְסוֹר עַצְמוֹ הֵן חֶלְקוֹ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה וְהֵן חֶלְקוֹ בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא בִּכְדֵי שֶׁיַּעֲשֶׂה רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא

The principle is that a person must serve the Creator, blessed be He, without seeking any reward at all, and surrender himself, both his portion in this world and his portion in the World to Come, in order to fulfill the Creator's will.

כְּמוֹ שֶׁמָּצִינוּ בְּרָחֵל שֶׁעָשְׂתָה הַמִּצְוָה לִמְסוֹר הַסִּימָנִים לְלֵאָה אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁעַל יְדֵי זֶה שׁוּב לֹא יִשָּׂא אוֹתָהּ יַעֲקֹב וְתַעֲלֶה אָל גּוֹרָלוֹ שֶׁל עֵשָׂו כַּנִּזְכָּר לְעֵיל וְנִמְצָא חַס וְשָׁלוֹם תֹּאבַד חֶלְקָהּ לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא כְּשֶׁיִּשָּׂא אוֹתָהּ עֵשָׂו חַס וְשָׁלוֹם אַף עַל פִּי כֵן מָסְרָה הַסִּימָנִים

As we find with Rochel, who performed the mitzvah of handing over the identifying signs to Leah, even though, through this, Yaakov would no longer marry her and she would fall to Esav's lot, as stated above. It would follow, Heaven forbid, that she would lose her portion in the World to Come if Esav were to marry her, Heaven

forbid. Nevertheless, she handed over the signs,

וּמָסְרָה עַצְמָהּ הֵן חֶלְקָהּ בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה הֵן בָּעוֹלָם הַבָּא בִּכְדֵי שֶׁיֵּעָשֶׂה רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא.

and surrendered herself, both her portion in this world and in the World to Come, in order that the Creator's will be fulfilled.

This additional Chassidic parallel explicitly states the general principle and illustrates it through Rochel giving Leah the identifying signs, despite the future she believed she might lose.

The Kedushas Levi adds what it cost her. When Rochel handed over the signs, she did not yet know that Yaakov would marry her as well. As far as she knew, she was giving up Yaakov, and with him her portion in the World to Come, since she might now fall to Esav's lot. And still she did it, so that the Creator's will would be done. Logic falls away at this point. The whole point is that one does not act in order to receive a prize.

EDITOR'S NOTE

In the shiur this passage was cited as Kedushas Levi on Parshas Vayeira. It is in Parshas Vayeitzei (26), where the Kedushas Levi builds on his comment at Vayeitzei 25, which in turn explains Rashi at Bereishis 30:22: "He remembered for her the signs that she gave to her sister."

With this in mind, we return to the Akeidah itself, and to what carried Avraham through it.

VII Awe, Love and the Gevurah of Yitzchak

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Pesach, maamar 52 · Shekalim, maamar 7 · Toldos, maamar 1 · Chanukah, maamar 15 · Bereishis 21:12, 22:12 · Ramban, Bereishis 22:1 · Michtav MeEliyahu I, Kuntres HaBechirah*

If Avraham served with no thought of reward, what moved him to bind his son? The obvious answer is love of Hashem. But the Pri Tzaddik makes a surprising point: love alone would have told Avraham to refuse.

What Love Would Have Said

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Pesach, maamar 52, paragraph 1 · Bereishis 21:12 · Bereishis 15:2*

Rav Tzadok sets out the argument in the Pri Tzaddik for Pesach:

PRI TZADDIK · PESACH, MAAMAR 52, PARAGRAPH 1

וְכֵן עַל פִּי מִדַּת אַהֲבָה זוֹ הָיָה צָרִיךְ לַעֲבוֹר עַל מִצְוַת עֲקֵידַת יִצְחָק. כֵּיוָן שֶׁיָּדַע כִּי בְיִצְחָק יִקָּרֵא לְךָ זֶרַע וְהַיְינוּ שֶׁעַל יָדוֹ יִתְפָּרְסֵם אֱלֹקִיתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ

Likewise, according to this attribute of love, he would have had reason to transgress the command of Akeidas Yitzchak, since he knew: Through Yitzchak shall offspring be called yours, meaning that through him His blessed Divinity would become known.

וְלֹא רָצָה שֶׁאֱלִיעֶזֶר יִהְיֶה הַמְפָרְסֵם אֱלֹקִיתוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ וּכְמוֹ שֶׁאָמַר וּבֶן מֶשֶׁק בֵּיתִי הוּא דַּמֶּשֶׂק אֱלִיעֶזֶר,

He did not want Eliezer to be the one who would proclaim His blessed Divinity, as he said: And the steward of my household is Eliezer of Damascus.

Hashem had told Avraham, כִּי בְיִצְחָק יִקָּרֵא לְךָ זָרַע, "for through Yitzchak shall offspring be called yours" (Bereishis 21:12). The future of Avraham's mission, the proclamation of Hashem's Divinity in the world, ran through Yitzchak. And Avraham did not want Eliezer, "the steward of my household" (Bereishis 15:2), to be the one who carried it on. So love of Hashem, and of His honor, itself gave Avraham a reason to refuse the command. (As an aside, the Midrash identifies Eliezer with Og: Pirkei DeRabbi Eliezer, cited in the Da'as Zekeinim at Bereishis 24:39.)

Awe: Suspecting His Own Heart

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Shekalim, maamar 7 · Toldos, maamar 1, paragraph 4 · Pesach, maamar 52*

And yet Avraham did not rely on that argument. Here is the turn, in the Pri Tzaddik for Parshas Shekalim:

> **PRI TZADDIK · PARSHAS SHEKALIM, MAAMAR 7, PARAGRAPH 1 (CONTINUED)**
>
> **THE AKEIDAH**
>
> אַף אָז הִשְׁתַּמֵּשׁ בְּמִדַּת הַיִּרְאָה בְּהַפְלָגָה וְנִתְיַיֵּרא לַעֲבוֹר עַל רְצוֹנוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ וְחָשַׁד אֶת עַצְמוֹ פֶּן הוּא נוֹגֵעַ מַה בַּדָּבָר לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ וְאָז נִתְכַּלֵּל בְּאֶשָׁא מִדַּת יִצְחָק
>
> *But then he exercised the attribute of awe to an extraordinary degree, and feared to transgress His blessed will, suspecting that perhaps his love for his son gave him some personal interest in the matter. He was then encompassed within the fire, the attribute of Yitzchak.*
>
> וְזֶה שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר בְּנִסָּיוֹן הָעֲקֵידָה עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים אַתָּה וְגוֹמֵר וְנִתְבָּאֵר תּוֹלְדוֹת מַאֲמָר א׳ דִּבּוּר הַמַּתְחִיל וּמַסִּיק וְהַיְינוּ שֶׁאָמַר מַה לִּי אִם אֵינִי מֵבִין כֵּיוָן שֶׁכָּךְ צִוִּיתִי אֲנִי מְחוּיָּב לִשְׁמוֹעַ.
>
> *This is what is stated in the trial of the Akeidah: Now I know that you fear God, and so forth as explained in Toldos, maamar 1, in the passage beginning Umasik. That is, he said: What does it matter that I do not understand? Since I have been commanded in this way, I am obligated to obey.*

The Pri Tzaddik speaks of an extraordinary degree of awe. As I read it, this is *yiras haromemus*, the awe that comes from standing before Hashem's exaltedness; the text does not say so outright, but that is what is implied. It was this awe that made Avraham afraid to transgress Hashem's word.

And what did he fear? That through his own love he might be transgressing Hashem's word. The Pri Tzaddik says that Avraham *suspected himself*: perhaps he was *noge'a b'davar*, personally involved in the matter, because love for his son might be tilting his judgment. His love for his son was also, in part, love of himself: his own ego, his own personal *hana'ah*. Was that getting in the way of serving Hashem? This was part of the inner struggle, and Avraham could not simply trust his own heart. The Pri Tzaddik sends us to Toldos, where he explains the same point:

> **PRI TZADDIK · TOLDOS, MAAMAR 1, PARAGRAPH 4**
>
> אַךְ מִיִּרְאָתוֹ הַמּוּפְלָגֶת יָרֵא לַעֲבוֹר פִּי הַשֵּׁם שֶׁחָשַׁשׁ אֶת עַצְמוֹ פֶּן הוּא נוֹגֵעַ מַה בַּדָּבָר לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ.
>
> *But because of his extraordinary awe, he feared to transgress Hashem's word, suspecting that perhaps his love for his son gave him some personal interest in the matter.*
>
> *Rav Tzadok first explains that Avraham's ahavah could have supplied an argument for preserving Yitzchak so that Hashem's Divinity would continue to be proclaimed through him. The following sentence explains why Avraham would not rely on that argument.*

I would connect this to Adam and Chava. What brought them down was the same pull: *hana'as atzmo*, one's own enjoyment, and the curiosity that the serpent aroused. The *avodah*, ultimately, is not to let one's own interest decide.

The Pri Tzaddik says it directly in the *maamar* for Pesach, continuing the passage we saw above:

> **PRI TZADDIK · PESACH, MAAMAR 52, PARAGRAPH 1 (CONTINUED)**
>
> אַךְ מִפְּנֵי יִרְאָתוֹ הָעֲצוּמָה לַעֲבוֹר עַל מִצְוֹת הַשֵּׁם שֶׁמָּא יֵשׁ לוֹ נְגִיעָה לְאַהֲבַת בְּנוֹ עַל פִּי מִדַּת הַיִּרְאָה הַזּוֹ עָקַד אֶת יִצְחָק בְּנוֹ,
>
> *But because of his tremendous fear of transgressing Hashem's command, lest his love for his son be influencing him, he bound his son Yitzchak in accordance with this attribute of awe.*
>
> וְזֶה שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר כִּי עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי יְרֵא אֱלֹקִים אַתָּה וְלֹא חָשַׂכְתָּ וְגוֹמֵר. וְאָז נִשְׁלַם בְּמִדַּת הָאַהֲבָה כְּשֶׁבָּא עַל יְדֵי יִרְאָה,
>
> *This is what is stated: For now I know that you fear God, and you have not withheld, and so forth. His attribute of love was then brought to completion when it came through awe.*

Awe completes love. Love by itself is not enough; it has to be completed by the strength that comes with awe, and love that arrives through awe is whole. That, as I understand it, is what Yitzchak personifies: love and awe together.

Chesed and Gevurah

SOURCE *Pri Tzaddik, Shekalim 7:1 · Chanukah 15 · Bereishis 31:42 · Bereishis 22:12*

Avraham is the attribute of *chesed*, lovingkindness; Yitzchak is the attribute of *gevurah*, strength and restraint. The Pri Tzaddik says that at the Akeidah Avraham "was encompassed within the fire, the attribute of Yitzchak." (Yaakov, too, calls Hashem "the Fear of Yitzchak": Bereishis 31:42.) What happened, as I understand it, is this. The *middah* of the Akeidah is to override his own love for his son. Because his fear of Hashem was so powerful, the *middah* of *gevurah* entered Avraham through Yitzchak, and in that moment he had within him a *middah* that was not inherent in him. The Akeidah itself brought it out.

This does not mean that love disappeared. Rav Tzadok returns to the Chanukah *maamar*:

> **PRI TZADDIK · CHANUKAH, MAAMAR 15 (CONTINUED)**
>
> וּמִכָּל מָקוֹם שִׁבְּחוֹ הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ בִּבְחִינַת יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים מִפְּנֵי שֶׁאָז עָשָׂה מִצְוַת הָאַהֲבָה בְּכֹחַ וּגְבוּרָה שֶׁבָּעֵר בּוֹ הָאַהֲבָה בְּשַׁלְהֶבֶת יָהּ.
>
> *Nevertheless, Hashem praised him as one who fears God, because then he fulfilled the mitzvah of love with strength and might, as love burned within him with a flame of God.*

Hashem praised him as *yerei Elokim*, one who fears God, because he had surrendered something dearer to him than his own life. To give up Yitzchak was to give up the extension of his own identity: without Yitzchak there would be no continuation of Avraham. Is that not the essence of *Yiddishkeit*? And this is what the verse says:

> **BEREISHIS 22:12**
>
> וַיֹּאמֶר אַל־תִּשְׁלַח יָדְךָ אֶל־הַנַּעַר וְאַל־תַּעַשׂ לוֹ מְאוּמָה כִּי עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי־יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים אַתָּה וְלֹא חָשַׂכְתָּ אֶת־בִּנְךָ אֶת־יְחִידְךָ מִמֶּנִּי׃
>
> *And He said: Do not stretch out your hand against the lad, and do nothing to him; for now I know that you fear God, since you have not withheld your son, your only one, from Me.*

The Ramban: What Is a Test For?

SOURCE *Ramban, Bereishis 22:1 · Tehillim 11:5*

There is an obvious question here. If Hashem tests only those who will pass, what is the test for? If the outcome is certain, is it a test at all? The Ramban addresses this at the very beginning of the Akeidah:

> **RAMBAN · BEREISHIS 22:1**
>
> וְהָאֱלֹקִים נִסָּה אֶת אַבְרָהָם עִנְיַן הַנִּסָּיוֹן הוּא לְדַעְתִּי בַּעֲבוּר הֱיוֹת מַעֲשֵׂה הָאָדָם רְשׁוּת מֻחְלָטֶת בְּיָדוֹ, אִם יִרְצֶה יַעֲשֶׂה וְאִם לֹא יִרְצֶה לֹא יַעֲשֶׂה, יִקָּרֵא "נִסָּיוֹן" מִצַּד הַמְנֻסֶּה, אֲבָל הַמְנַסֶּה יִתְבָּרַךְ יְצַוֶּה בּוֹ לְהוֹצִיא הַדָּבָר מִן הַכֹּחַ אֶל הַפֹּעַל, לִהְיוֹת לוֹ שָׂכָר מַעֲשֶׂה טוֹב, לֹא שְׂכַר לֵב טוֹב בִּלְבַד.
>
> *"And God tested Avraham." The matter of the test is, in my opinion, as follows. Since a person's deed is entirely in his own hands—if he wishes he does it, and if he does not wish he does not—it is called a "test" from the standpoint of the one being tested. But the One who tests, blessed be He, commands it in order to bring the matter out of potential and into actuality, so that he will have the reward of a good deed, and not only the reward of a good heart.*
>
> דַּע כִּי הַשֵּׁם צַדִּיק יִבְחָן [תהלים י״א:ה׳], כְּשֶׁהוּא יוֹדֵעַ בְּצַדִּיק שֶׁיַּעֲשֶׂה רְצוֹנוֹ וְחָפֵץ לְהַצְדִּיקוֹ יְצַוֶּה אוֹתוֹ בְּנִסָּיוֹן, וְלֹא יִבְחַן אֶת הָרְשָׁעִים אֲשֶׁר לֹא יִשְׁמְעוּ. וְהִנֵּה כָּל הַנִּסְיוֹנוֹת שֶׁבַּתּוֹרָה לְטוֹבַת הַמְנֻסֶּה.
>
> *Know that "Hashem tests the righteous" (Tehillim 11:5): when He knows of a righteous man that he will do His will, and He desires to justify him, He commands him with a test; but He does not test the wicked, who will not listen. And behold, all the tests in the Torah are for the benefit of the one tested.*

So the test is for the sake of the person tested. Hashem does not need to learn what Avraham will do. The test exists so that what is only potential becomes actual: not merely to talk the talk, but to walk the walk, and so to earn the reward of a deed, and not only the reward of a good heart.

But the question can be pressed. If Avraham was always going to pass, and the capacity was always there, is it really a test? Here the shiur turns to Rav Dessler, as recorded on this very verse in the Sha'arei Aharon.

Rav Dessler: The Point of Choice

SOURCE *Sha'arei Aharon, Vayeira, on Bereishis 22:1 (p. 977) · Michtav MeEliyahu, Vol. I, Kuntres HaBechirah, chs. 2–4 (pp. 113–116)*

As I understand Rav Dessler, he takes the Ramban's idea of potential and actual a step further: the test itself brings out new *kochos*, abilities that did not exist before. His comment on this Ramban is recorded in the Sha'arei Aharon, on the very same verse. The author sets out the Ramban, and then adds what he received from his teacher:

SHA'AREI AHARON · VAYEIRA, ON BEREISHIS 22:1 (P. 977)

ON THE WORD "NISSAH"

The author has just summarized the Ramban: the test is not meant to teach Hashem anything, but to bring Avraham's perfection out of potential into actuality, adding worth in the one who is tested. He continues:

וּלְפִי זֶה מַה שֶּׁכָּתוּב "נִסָּה" פֵּרוּשׁוֹ שֶׁהוּא רוֹמֵם אוֹתוֹ, מִלְּשׁוֹן "נָתַתָּה לִירֵאֶיךָ נֵס לְהִתְנוֹסֵס"

Accordingly, when the verse says "He tested [nissah]," it means that He raised him up, from the expression "You have given those who fear You a banner [nes] to be raised high" (Tehillim 60:6).

וְכֵן קִבַּלְתִּי מִמּוֹרִי וְרַבִּי הַגָּאוֹן הַצַּדִּיק רַבִּי אֵלִיָּהוּ אֱלִיעֶזֶר דֶּסְלֶר זִכְרוֹנוֹ לִבְרָכָה לְחַיֵּי הָעוֹלָם הַבָּא, דִּכְשֶׁאָדָם עוֹמֵד בְּנִסָּיוֹן, הוּא עוֹלֶה בְּדַרְגָּא בִּנְקֻדַּת הַבְּחִירָה שֶׁלּוֹ, כְּלוֹמַר בַּדָּבָר הַזֶּה שֶׁנִּתְנַסָּה וְעָמַד בּוֹ, כְּבָר אֵין לוֹ יוֹתֵר בְּחִירָה בְּעִנְיָן זֶה, וּמֵעַתָּה הַבְּחִירָה שֶׁלּוֹ בְּדַרְגָּא יוֹתֵר גָּבוֹהַּ, וּמַה שֶּׁכָּתוּב "נִסָּה" מִתְפָּרֵשׁ כִּפְשׁוּטוֹ, שֶׁמֵּעַתָּה נִתְרוֹמֵם.

And so I received from my master and teacher, the righteous gaon Rabbi Eliyahu Eliezer Dessler, of blessed memory, for life in the World to Come: when a person stands firm in a test, he rises a level in his point of choice. That is, in this very matter in which he was tested and stood firm, he no longer has any choice; and from now on his choice is at a higher level. And what is written, "He tested [nissah]," is explained according to its plain sense: that from now on he has been raised up.

THE SFORNO ON "HE TESTED AVRAHAM," AS CITED THERE

כְּדֵי שֶׁיִּהְיֶה בַּפֹּעַל "אוֹהֵב וְיָרֵא" כְּמוֹ שֶׁהָיָה בַּכֹּחַ

So that he would be, in actuality, "one who loves and fears," as he had been in potential.

Hebrew as printed in the Sha'arei Aharon, with abbreviations expanded and the text vocalized, and checked against the printed page. The author's summary of the Ramban, omitted here, cites the HaKsav VeHaKabbalah, the Zohar and the Ramban.

Notice what the Sha'arei Aharon says. A test does not merely reveal a strength that was already there; it raises the person. Having stood firm, he no longer has a choice in that matter, because it is settled for him, and his point of choice moves up to a higher level. To see what this means, we need Rav Dessler's

teaching on the point of choice itself, which he sets out in the Kuntres HaBechirah (Michtav MeEliyahu, Volume I):

RAV DESSLER · MICHTAV MEELIYAHU, VOL. I, KUNTRES HABECHIRAH, CHS. 2–4 (PP. 113–116)

We are not equally free in every area of life. Rav Dessler pictures two armies facing each other on a front. Behind one line lies territory that belongs wholly to the *yetzer hara*; behind the other, territory that belongs wholly to the *yetzer hatov*; and between them lies a contested strip. What a person does in the first two zones is habit, upbringing and nature, and he does not choose it afresh each time. Free choice operates only at the front: the *nekudas habechirah* (ch. 2, pp. 113–114).

The point does not stay in one place. אמנם נקודה זו של הבחירה אינה עומדת תמיד על מצב אחד ("Yet this point of choice does not always remain in one position"; ch. 3, p. 115). A person who wins his struggle makes it second nature, and the front moves forward into territory that was once beyond him; one who loses sees the reverse. What was a struggle becomes a habit, and a new struggle appears at a higher level. The Mishnah in Avos describes the same pattern: שְׂמִצְוָה גּוֹרֶרֶת מִצְוָה, וַעֲבֵרָה גּוֹרֶרֶת עֲבֵרָה ("one *mitzvah* draws another *mitzvah*, and one *aveirah* draws another *aveirah*"; Avos 4:2).

Reward follows the point of choice. A person's real merit lies in his own choices at that front. What he was raised to do only prepares the place where his point of choice stands, and the reward for it belongs largely to those who raised him (ch. 4).

Now apply this to Avraham. Everyone has a point of choice, and before the command Avraham Avinu would never have sacrificed his son. It was not an option, not even at the front line of his choice. Then came the test. He went as far as taking the knife, until the call came, "Avraham, Avraham," and the angels wept, their tears falling into Yitzchak's eyes (Rashi on Bereishis 27:1, citing Bereishis Rabbah 65:10). From then on, as I understand it, giving up Yitzchak became a real option for him, because Hashem had made it one. And once he had stood firm, the matter was settled, and his point of choice moved on to a higher level, as the Sha'arei Aharon records.

Here is another picture. A man is being chased, *chas veshalom*, and he must leap from one building to the next. He would never have dreamed of trying it, but he has no choice, and the situation itself brings out an ability that did not exist before. That is the point of choice moving, and that is how I understand Rav Dessler's comment on this Ramban: a test lifts a person to a place he could not have reached before.

A PARALLEL · RABBI AKIVA TATZ, "ORDEALS"

The same idea appears in a shiur by Rabbi Akiva Tatz on the nature of ordeals. He begins with the word itself. *Nisayon* is built on the root *nes*, which means a miracle, and also a banner raised high, a rallying point above the confusion of the battlefield. But where is the miracle in a test? If a person only reveals a capacity he already had, nothing miraculous has happened. The Sha'arei Aharon, quoted above, reads "nissah" the same way: He raised him up.

Rabbi Tatz then asks the question that the Ramban answers: if Hashem knows beforehand what a person will do, what is the test for? The answer usually given to young people, he says, is that the test is not for Hashem but for the person, who needs to bring his hidden potential into actuality. (This is the Ramban's answer, though the shiur does not name him.) It is true, he says, but it is only a first step.

Why is it not enough? Because a test pitched within a person's capacity, even a capacity he never knew he had, is not a miracle: nothing impossible has happened. And if every test were pitched within his capacity, he could at most bring out the fullness of what he already is. There would be a ceiling, and no real growth. So a real test, one that he did not choose for himself, takes him beyond even his true limit. When Hashem tells him to leap, and he leaps, Hashem carries him across. That is the miracle.

As for the saying that Hashem never gives a test that a person cannot pass, Rabbi Tatz explains that it does not mean the test is within his capacity. It means that if he leaps into it, he will be lifted. Rabbi Tatz does not cite Rav Dessler in this shiur, but the two meet at one point: a test does not merely reveal what a person is. It lifts him higher.

Editor's note on the source

The shiur gave no reference for this comment of Rav Dessler. It is in the Sha'arei Aharon on this verse (p. 977), whose author presents it as something he received from his teacher, Rav Dessler, and not as a citation from a book. I have not seen it in the Michtav MeEliyahu. The principle on which it rests, the *nekudas habechirah*, is in the Kuntres HaBechirah, quoted above.

The shiur's wording that the test "brings out new *kochos*," and its picture of the leap between buildings, are the shiur's own way of explaining the idea. The Sha'arei Aharon says only that a person who stands firm in a test rises a level in his point of choice.

Rav Dessler on this week's parashah · Kuntres HaBechirah, ch. 4

In chapter 4, Rav Dessler turns to education. A person's merits, he concludes, lie in his own good choices, and not in the *mitzvos* and good deeds that he was raised to do. To illustrate, he brings a teaching of the Alter of Slabodka, Rav Nosson Tzvi Finkel, about Lot, from this week's *parashah*. Lot grew up in Avraham's house, and he rose in *chesed*. When the angels came to Sedom he pressed them to stay with him, and when the mob came to break down his door, he risked his life for his guests (Bereishis 19). Yet when the Torah tells why Lot was saved, it says:

וַיְהִי בְּשַׁחֵת אֱלֹהִים אֶת־עָרֵי הַכִּכָּר וַיִּזְכֹּר אֱלֹהִים אֶת־אַבְרָהָם וַיְשַׁלַּח אֶת־לוֹט מִתּוֹךְ הַהֲפֵכָה בַּהֲפֹךְ אֶת־הֶעָרִים אֲשֶׁר־יָשַׁב בָּהֶן לוֹט

And it was, when God destroyed the cities of the plain, that God remembered Avraham, and He sent Lot out from the midst of the upheaval, when He overturned the cities in which Lot had dwelt.

And Rashi asks what that remembrance was:

ויזכור אלהים את אברהם. מַהוּ זְכִירָתוֹ שֶׁל אַבְרָהָם עַל לוֹט? נִזְכַּר שֶׁהָיָה לוֹט יוֹדֵעַ שֶׁשָּׂרָה אִשְׁתּוֹ שֶׁל אַבְרָהָם וְשָׁמַע שֶׁאָמַר אַבְרָהָם בְּמִצְרַיִם עַל שָׂרָה אֲחוֹתִי הִיא, וְלֹא גִלָּה הַדָּבָר, שֶׁהָיָה חָס עָלָיו, לְפִיכָךְ חָס הַקָּבָ״ה עָלָיו

[בראשית רבה]

"And God remembered Avraham." What was this remembrance of Avraham concerning Lot? He remembered that Lot knew that Sarah was Avraham's wife, and he heard Avraham say in Egypt of Sarah, "She is my sister," and he did not reveal the matter, for he had pity on him; therefore the Holy One, blessed be He, had pity on him. [Bereishis Rabbah 51:6]

The Alter's lesson is that Lot's rescue is credited not to the *chesed* that came easily to him, even at the risk of his life, but to the one place where he overcame himself. Whatever reaches a person through his upbringing, even to the point of *mesiras nefesh*, is not his true level; his true level lies in overcoming his *yetzer* in something he was never taught.

In his shiur on this chapter, Rabbi Dr. Yaakov Abramovitz adds two points. Lot's nature drew him toward money and the luxury of Sedom, and revealing Avraham's secret could have made him rich; so keeping silent was an act within Lot's own point of choice. And *chesed* was Avraham's gift, while *gevurah* may not have been; for Yitzchak, who was all *gevurah*, it may have been *chesed* that was hard.

So it was with Avraham. *Chesed* was his nature, and the Akeidah asked of him the opposite *middah*, *gevurah*, which entered him through Yitzchak. And that is why Hashem could say, at the end:

כִּי עַתָּה יָדַעְתִּי כִּי־יְרֵא אֱלֹהִים אַתָּה

For now I know that you fear God. (Bereishis 22:12)

VIII Faith Beyond Understanding

SOURCE *Rashi on Bereishis 22:12 (Bereishis Rabbah 56:7–8) · Bereishis 15:5, 17:21, 22:2 · Mei HaShiloach I, Vayeira 8 · Taanis 4a · Sanhedrin 97a–b, 98a · Tehillim 90:4 · Rambam, Hilchos Melachim 12:2*

So far we have followed Avraham's struggle with his feelings: his love for Yitzchak, and his suspicion that this love might be bending his judgment. There was a second struggle, and it was a struggle of understanding. Hashem had promised him descendants through Yitzchak, and now Hashem was asking for Yitzchak's life. How could both be true?

FROM THE ROOM · AVRAHAM'S OTHER QUESTION

Comment: I don't think Rav Tzadok brings in the Rashi here. As I understand it, there was another thought running through Avraham's mind, and it was not about his love for his son. It was this: how can Hashem promise me descendants if I am killing my only descendant? That was part of the *yetzer hara*'s back-and-forth too, I suppose.

Response: Rashi brings it, from the Midrash. Avraham speaks to Hashem at the point where Hashem says, "Do not touch him," and Avraham wakes up and says: "We have to have a discussion here. I am confused. You told me I would have children, and then You told me to sacrifice him. It is contradictory. What is going on?" And Hashem answers: "I never contradicted Myself, nor misled you. You misunderstood."

Rashi: "Let Me Lay Out My Conversation"

SOURCE *Rashi on Bereishis 22:12 · Bereishis Rabbah 56:7–8 · Tehillim 89:35*

Here is the Rashi on the verse "Do not stretch out your hand against the lad" (Bereishis 22:12). He first records Avraham's reaction, and then, on the words "for now I know," the conversation I described:

RASHI · BEREISHIS 22:12

אל תשלח. לִשְׁחֹט; אָמַר לוֹ אִם כֵּן לְחִנָּם בָּאתִי לְכָאן, אֶעֱשֶׂה בּוֹ חַבָּלָה וְאוֹצִיא מִמֶּנּוּ מְעַט דָּם, אָמַר לוֹ אל תעש לו מאומה – אַל תַּעַשׂ בּוֹ מוּם

"Do not stretch out"—to slaughter. He said to Him: If so, I have come here for nothing! Let me make a wound in him and draw a little blood. He said to him: "and do nothing to him"—do not make a blemish in him.

כי עתה ידעתי. אָמַר רַבִּי אַבָּא, אָמַר לוֹ אַבְרָהָם אֲפָרֵשׁ לְפָנֶיךָ אֶת שִׂיחָתִי, אֶתְמוֹל אָמַרְתָּ לִי כִּי בְיִצְחָק יִקָּרֵא לְךָ זָרַע, וְחָזַרְתָּ וְאָמַרְתָּ קַח נָא אֶת בִּנְךָ, עַכְשָׁו אַתָּה אוֹמֵר אַל תִּשְׁלַח יָדְךָ אֶל הַנַּעַר? אָמַר לוֹ הַקָּבָ"ה, לֹא אֲחַלֵּל בְּרִיתִי וּמוֹצָא שְׂפָתַי לֹא אָשַׁנֶּה [תהילים פ״ט]; כְּשֶׁאָמַרְתִּי לְךָ "קַח", מוֹצָא שְׂפָתַי לֹא אָשַׁנֶּה – לֹא אָמַרְתִּי לְךָ שְׁחָטֵהוּ אֶלָּא הַעֲלֵהוּ, אַסַּקְתֵּיהּ, אַחְתֵּיהּ.

"For now I know." Rabbi Abba said: Avraham said to Him, "Let me lay out before You my conversation. Yesterday You said to me, 'For through Yitzchak shall offspring be called yours'; then You went back and said, 'Take your son'; and now You say, 'Do not stretch out your hand against the lad'?" The Holy One, blessed be He, said to him: "I will not profane My covenant, nor change what has gone out of My lips" (Tehillim 89:35). When I said to you "Take," I did not say "slaughter him" but "bring him up." You have brought him up; now bring him down.

Rashi names Rabbi Abba; the printed Bereishis Rabbah (56:8) reads Rabbi Acha.

There was no contradiction in Hashem's word, only a misreading of it. Hashem had said *ha'alehu*, "bring him up," and Avraham understood it as "slaughter him." He acted on that understanding with his whole heart, and only afterward learned that the difficulty lay in his understanding, and not in Hashem's word.

That is worth remembering. If Avraham, who heard the command directly from Hashem, could misread it, then we have to be very careful about how we read what has been said about the future.

A Caution About Reading Prophecy

SOURCE *Sanhedrin 97a–b, 98a · Tehillim 90:4 · Rambam, Hilchos Melachim 12:2*

This brings up a parenthetical point. The commentators allude to future events, and what they say is true, but we often do not grasp its full weight, even when we have the commentary in hand. The date of the Redemption is the classic example. Over the centuries a number of years have been named; in the discussion the Ramban and the Chasam Sofer were mentioned. **[source to be added: the Ramban's and the Chasam Sofer's dates for the Redemption, as mentioned in the room]**

There is also the belief, which we have heard since childhood, that Mashiach comes in the year 6000, and that this is the end time, though he could come earlier. It rests on the Gemara in Sanhedrin (97a). The school of Eliyahu taught that the world endures six thousand years: two thousand of chaos, two thousand of Torah, and two thousand days of Mashiach. And Rav Ketina taught that the world endures six thousand years, and for one thousand it lies in ruins. The Baraisa brings a verse in Tehillim (90:4) to show that a thousand years are as one day. So the six thousand years are the six days of the week, and the year 6000 would be *erev Shabbos*.

But how do we know that we are reading it correctly? Mashiach can come today; after all, 6000 is still more than two centuries away. The Gemara itself reads the verse in Yeshayahu (60:22), "in its time I

will hasten it," as two possibilities: if they merit, *achishenah*, "I will hasten it"; if they do not merit, *be'itah*, "in its time" (Sanhedrin 98a).

The Gemara is wary of all this calculation. Rabbi Zeira, finding some of the Sages calculating the end, pleaded with them: "I beg you, do not delay his coming by calculating the end of days." He taught that three things come only when the mind is turned elsewhere: Mashiach, a lost article, and a scorpion (97a). A little later Rabbi Yonasan says, in the strongest terms, "May the bones of those who calculate the end burst," and the answer he gives is the verse in Chavakuk (2:3): "Though it tarry, wait for it" (97b). The Rambam rules accordingly:

RAMBAM · HILCHOS MELACHIM 12:2

וְכָל אֵלּוּ הַדְּבָרִים וְכַיּוֹצֵא בָּהֶן לֹא יֵדַע אָדָם אֵיךְ יִהְיוּ עַד שֶׁיִּהְיוּ. שֶׁדְּבָרִים סְתוּמִין הֵן אֵצֶל הַנְּבִיאִים.

And as for all these matters and their like, no one will know how they will be until they come to be. For these matters are sealed among the prophets.

וְכֵן לֹא יְחַשֵּׁב הַקִּצִּין. אָמְרוּ חֲכָמִים תִּפַּח רוּחָם שֶׁל מְחַשְּׁבֵי הַקִּצִּים. אֶלָּא יְחַכֶּה וְיַאֲמִין בִּכְלַל הַדָּבָר.

And so one should not calculate the end. The Sages said: "May the spirit of those who calculate the ends burst." Rather, one should wait, and believe in the general principle.

In Sanhedrin 97b the wording is "their bones"; this edition of the Rambam reads "their spirit."

And what if we do not understand a *derashah* at all? The Rambam's answer, too, is that we do not understand the midrash, and that is the honest thing to say. Or else we simply do what Hashem tells us, and that is Avraham Avinu.

Believing Both at Once

SOURCE *Mei HaShiloach I, Vayeira 8 · Bereishis 15:5, 17:21, 22:2*

Avraham did not resolve the apparent contradiction. He believed both sides of it. Hashem had said three things to him:

THREE STATEMENTS · BEREISHIS 15:5 · 17:21 · 22:2

כֹּה יִהְיֶה זַרְעֶךָ

"So shall your offspring be." (Bereishis 15:5)

וְאֶת־בְּרִיתִי אָקִים אֶת־יִצְחָק

"But My covenant I will establish with Yitzchak." (Bereishis 17:21)

וְהַעֲלֵהוּ שָׁם לְעֹלָה

"And bring him up there as a burnt offering." (Bereishis 22:2)

And this is how the Mei HaShiloach reads the test:

MEI HASHILOACH I · VAYEIRA 8

וְהָאֱלֹקִים נִסָּה אֶת אַבְרָהָם. עִנְיַן נִסָּיוֹן שֶׁל הָעֲקֵדָה הָיָה גֹּדֶל הָאֱמוּנָה שֶׁהָיָה לְאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ בְּהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ, כִּי אַף שֶׁאָמַר לוֹ כֹּה יִהְיֶה זַרְעֶךָ,

And God tested Avraham. The matter tested at the Akeidah was the greatness of Avraham Avinu's faith in Hashem. For although He had told him: So shall your offspring be,

וְנֶאֱמַר לוֹ אֶת בְּרִיתִי אָקִים אֶת יִצְחָק, וְעַכְשָׁיו כְּשֶׁנֶּאֱמַר לוֹ הַעֲלֵהוּ לְעוֹלָה עִם כָּל זֶה הֶאֱמִין בַּדְּבָרִים הָרִאשׁוֹנִים כְּמוֹ מִקֹּדֶם וְלֹא נָפְלוּ אֶצְלוֹ, וְזֹאת הָאֱמוּנָה אֵין בְּשֵׂכֶל הָאָדָם לְהַשִּׂיג,

and he had been told: I shall establish My covenant with Yitzchak, and now he was told: Bring him up as a burnt offering, nevertheless he believed in the earlier statements just as before, and they did not lose their standing for him. This faith is beyond the grasp of human understanding.

This passage adds a distinct dimension: Avraham retained his faith in Hashem's earlier promises even while proceeding with the Akeidah. It does not explicitly state that he forfeited Olam Haba.

For the Mei HaShiloach, then, the test of the Akeidah was the greatness of Avraham's faith. He went forward with the new command and held on to the old promises, without resolving the tension between them. It is a faith beyond the reach of human understanding.

What does it mean to listen to Hashem? The real *tzivui*, the real command, is to do things even when they do not make sense, and not to overthink them. That was Avraham's level. He simply listened, though by any rational measure, what was going on? The Sfas Emes describes this listening from the inside, in terms of the will, and that is where we go next.

A PARALLEL · RABBI AKIVA TATZ, "ORDEALS" · TAANIS 4A

Rabbi Tatz makes a related point about what made the Akeidah impossible for Avraham. The Gemara (Taanis 4a) applies the words of Yirmiyahu (19:5), "which I did not command, nor speak, nor did it come into My heart," to three cases: the son of Mesha, king of Moav; the daughter of Yiftach; and Yitzchak.

"וְלֹא עָלְתָה עַל לִבִּי" — זֶה יִצְחָק בֶּן אַבְרָהָם.

"Nor did it come into My heart"—this is Yitzchak, son of Avraham.

From this Rabbi Tatz concludes that Avraham knew, as a beloved knows the heart of his beloved, that Hashem did not want it. So the impossibility was not emotional, for Avraham's self-control was supreme. It lay in his mind: he was commanded to do what he knew Hashem did not desire, and he had to put his own understanding aside and do it. He quotes the Alter of Kelm: do not ask whether a thing is possible; ask only whether it is necessary.

In the transcript of that shiur the Gemara is given as Nazir and the verse as Tehillim; the passage is Taanis 4a, on Yirmiyahu 19:5.

IX Nefesh Is Ratzon

SOURCE *Sfas Emes, Balak 5656 · Devarim 4:35 · Bereishis 22:3 · Pesachim 4a · Midrash Tanchuma, Vayeira 22 · Pirkei Avos 5:16 · Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55*

What, finally, is *mesiras nefesh*? The Sfas Emes gives a precise answer, and it brings together everything we have seen.

> SFAS EMES · BALAK, 5656, SECOND PARAGRAPH
>
> NEFESH MEANS WILL
>
> כִּי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם הָיָה הָרִאשׁוֹן שֶׁמָּסַר נַפְשׁוֹ לְשֵׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ וּבָאֱמֶת בִּמְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ זוֹכִין אֶל זֶה הַזְּרִיזוּת
>
> *For Avraham Avinu, peace be upon him, was the first to surrender his life for His blessed Name. Through mesiras nefesh, one truly merits this alacrity:*
>
> לִהְיוֹת כָּל רְצוֹנוֹ תָּמִיד רַק לַעֲשׂוֹת רְצוֹן הַבּוֹרֵא וְאֵין לוֹ דָּבָר אַחֵר בָּעוֹלָם זֶה מִקְּרֵי מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ כִּי נֶפֶשׁ הוּא רָצוֹן וְעַל יְדֵי מְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ בְּפוֹעַל זוֹכִין לָזֶה הָרָצוֹן.
>
> *that his entire will should always be only to fulfill the Creator's will, with nothing else in his world. This is called mesiras nefesh, for nefesh means will, and through actual mesiras nefesh one merits this will.*

The Sfas Emes defines the word. *Nefesh*, in this sense, is *ratzon*, will. To give up one's *nefesh* is therefore to give up one's own will, so that one's whole will becomes only to do the will of the Creator, with nothing else in one's world. That is what happened to Avraham. His ego, and in this case the rationalizing that is part of the ego, no longer stood in the way. He was locked in, in complete sync with Hashem; he did not deviate, and he did not overthink. And through actual *mesiras nefesh*, the Sfas Emes adds, one merits this will.

Nullifying the Self

SOURCE *Devarim 4:35*

This is a concept found throughout Chassidus: *bitul hayesh*, the nullification of one's sense of independent existence. It is the hardest thing in the world. Chabad speaks of it often: fundamentally, we do not really exist. What does that mean? The only reason we exist at all is Hashem. The only true existence is Hashem, as the verse says:

> DEVARIM 4:35
>
> אַתָּה הָרְאֵתָ לָדַעַת כִּי ה׳ הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים אֵין עוֹד מִלְבַדּוֹ
>
> *You were shown, so that you would know that Hashem, He is God; there is none besides Him.*

If we really existed, we would be existing independently of Hashem, and that cannot be. That is the bigger picture.

Zerizus

SOURCE *Bereishis 22:3 · Pesachim 4a · Midrash Tanchuma, Vayeira 22*

The Sfas Emes calls the fruit of *mesiras nefesh zerizus*, alacrity: a will with nothing standing in its way. Avraham's alacrity is written into the verse itself, and the Sages drew the lesson from it:

AVRAHAM'S ZERIZUS

BEREISHIS 22:3

וַיַּשְׁכֵּם אַבְרָהָם בַּבֹּקֶר וַיַּחֲבֹשׁ אֶת־חֲמֹרוֹ וַיִּקַּח אֶת־שְׁנֵי נְעָרָיו אִתּוֹ וְאֵת יִצְחָק בְּנוֹ וַיְבַקַּע עֲצֵי עֹלָה וַיָּקָם וַיֵּלֶךְ אֶל־הַמָּקוֹם אֲשֶׁר־אָמַר־לוֹ הָאֱלֹהִים

And Avraham arose early in the morning and saddled his donkey; and he took his two young men with him, and Yitzchak his son; and he split the wood for the burnt offering, and he arose and went to the place of which God had told him.

PESACHIM 4A

זְרִיזִין מַקְדִּימִין לְמִצְוֹת, שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: ״וַיַּשְׁכֵּם אַבְרָהָם בַּבֹּקֶר״.

The zealous hasten to the mitzvos, as it is said: "And Avraham arose early in the morning."

MIDRASH TANCHUMA · VAYEIRA 22

כַּמָּה עֲבָדִים וְכַמָּה שְׁפָחוֹת הָיוּ לוֹ לְאוֹתוֹ צַדִּיק, וְהוּא בְּעַצְמוֹ וַיַּחֲבֹשׁ אֶת חֲמוֹרוֹ, לְלַמֶּדְךָ זְרִיזוּתוֹ.

How many servants and maidservants that righteous man had, and yet he himself "saddled his donkey"—to teach you his zeal.

This is a beautiful idea about *zerizus* in general: an instinct that does not let our own rationalizing in, and simply wants to do the *mitzvah* right away. That is the Avraham Avinu inside each of us. Every day we have the opportunity to do a *mitzvah* with *zerizus*: going to the first *minyan*, being there on time, *vasikin*, and the same with any *mitzvah*.

Without Conditions

SOURCE *Sfas Emes, Balak 5656 · Pirkei Avos 5:16 · Beis Yaakov on Torah, Vayeira, ois 55*

The Sfas Emes continues, and here he speaks of the disciples of Avraham:

SFAS EMES · BALAK, 5656 (CONTINUED)

LOVE INDEPENDENT OF REWARD

אֲכָל תַּלְמִידֵי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם לִהְיוֹת עוֹבֵד הַשֵּׁם שֶׁלֹּא עַל מְנָת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס רַק לִשְׁמוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ בִּלְבַד. וּמְסִירַת נֶפֶשׁ הוּא עֵדוּת עַל זֶה שֶׁהִיא שֶׁלֹּא עַל מְנָת לְקַבֵּל פְּרָס

The disciples of Avraham Avinu, however, seek to serve Hashem without the intention of receiving reward, solely for His blessed Name. Mesiras nefesh testifies that this service is without the intention of receiving reward,

כִּי מִי שֶׁמּוֹסֵר נַפְשׁוֹ וּמְאוֹדוֹ לַשָּׁמַיִם הִיא אַהֲבָה שֶׁאֵינָהּ תְּלוּיָה בְּדָבָר וְלָכֵן אֵינָהּ בְּטֵלָה לְעוֹלָם.

for when someone surrenders his life and his resources to Heaven, this is a love independent of any condition, and therefore it never ceases.

To be a disciple of Avraham Avinu is to seek to serve Hashem without any intention of reward, for His Name alone. *Mesiras nefesh* is the testimony to that: when a person gives himself up, the ulterior motives disappear, and his own enjoyment makes no difference. The Sfas Emes speaks of the two levels, a person's life and his resources, "with all your soul and with all your might" (Devarim 6:5), given over for the sake of Heaven. And a love of this kind has no conditions attached to it, and so it never ceases. The Mishnah in Avos gives the principle:

PIRKEI AVOS 5:16

כָּל אַהֲבָה שֶׁהִיא תְלוּיָה בְדָבָר, בָּטֵל דָּבָר, בְּטֵלָה אַהֲבָה. וְשֶׁאֵינָהּ תְּלוּיָה בְדָבָר, אֵינָהּ בְּטֵלָה לְעוֹלָם.

Any love that depends on something—when the thing ceases, the love ceases; but love that does not depend on anything never ceases.

The Mishnah's examples are the love of Amnon and Tamar, which depended on something, and the love of Dovid and Yehonasan, which depended on nothing. Avraham's love for Hashem was of the second kind, and the Beis Yaakov, whom we met in Section III, draws the same conclusion for any *mitzvah*:

BEIS YAAKOV ON TORAH · VAYEIRA, OIS 55 (CONTINUED)

ITS EXPRESSION IN AN ORDINARY MITZVAH

וְאִם עוֹשֶׂה מִצְוַת הַשֵּׁם בְּלִי שׁוּם פְּנִיָּה רַק לִרְצוֹן הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרֵךְ, אָז נוֹגֵעַ הַפְּעוּלָה מַעְלָה מַעְלָה, שֶׁהֲיָה לָהּ אֲחִיזָה בַּעֲקֵידַת יִצְחָק,

If he performs Hashem's mitzvah without any ulterior motive, solely for Hashem's will, then the act reaches higher and higher, so that it has a connection to Akeidas Yitzchak.

After describing the Akeidah, the Beis Yaakov extends the principle to an ordinary mitzvah performed entirely for Hashem.

What Avraham did on the mountain is not for Avraham alone. A *mitzvah* done for Hashem's will alone, with no ulterior motive, reaches higher and higher, and has a hold in the Akeidas Yitzchak.

A PARALLEL · A TRANSCRIBED SHIUR, "FREE WILL — THE REAL YOU"

A transcribed shiur on free will, "Free Will — The Real You," makes a point that sheds light on the Sfas Emes. (The transcript does not name the speaker.) Free will, it says, lives in *ratzon*, the faculty of will and desire, which is the root of consciousness: the place with nothing prior to it. The word *ratzon* has the same numerical value as *makor*, "source"; both come to 346.

At that root, the shiur says, a person can want only one thing at a time. Many desires may fight to be the one, but only one can pass through and activate action. So the battle of free will is: which desire will I let in? If, as the Sfas Emes says, *nefesh* is *ratzon*, then *mesiras nefesh* is the handing over of the very place where free will lives.

X What Is Our Obligation?

SOURCE *Mesillas Yesharim 1*

After everything is said about giving up Olam Haba, and all of it is true, there is something more basic: the reward is not what makes the difference. It becomes irrelevant. All one wants is to serve Hashem. That is really our *avodah*, and what the whole world should see: our only existence is an extension of Hashem in the first place. And that is what the Ramchal means at the opening of Mesillas Yesharim:

> **MESILLAS YESHARIM · CHAPTER 1**
>
> יְסוֹד הַחֲסִידוּת וְשֹׁרֶשׁ הָעֲבוֹדָה הַתְּמִימָה הוּא שֶׁיִּתְבָּרֵר וְיִתְאַמֵּת אֵצֶל הָאָדָם מָה חוֹבָתוֹ בְּעוֹלָמוֹ וּלְמָה צָרִיךְ שָׁיָּשִׂים מַבָּטוֹ וּמַגַּמָּתוֹ בְּכָל אֲשֶׁר הוּא עָמֵל כָּל יְמֵי חַיָּיו.
>
> *The foundation of piety and the root of wholehearted service is that it become clear and established for a person what his obligation is in his world, and toward what he must set his gaze and his aim in all that he labors, all the days of his life.*

When we give a talk, especially in *kiruv*, and are asked what the purpose of life is, we often say that it is Olam Haba, the bigger picture. In the same chapter the Ramchal does say that man was created to delight in Hashem, and that the place of this delight is Olam Haba. Even so, the question he sets at the opening is a different one. It is not "what will he receive?" but *mah chovaso*, "what is his obligation?" The word *chovah* means an obligation, even a debt. It is about what Hashem wants, and not about us; our own wants are meant to be with Hashem's will.

Let us have this *middah* of *zerizus*, in the way Hashem teaches us to give ourselves over, with no exceptions. The only question is: what does Hashem want?

כִּי נֶפֶשׁ הוּא רָצוֹן

For nefesh is will. (Sfas Emes, Balak 5656)

Have a good Shabbos.

Index of Sources

Every source cited in this document, by category.

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Chumash	Bereishis 2:17 · 9:5 · 12:1 · 15:2, 15:5 · 17:21 · 19:29 · 21:12 · 22:1–3, 22:12 · 24:39 · 27:1 · 30:22 · 31:42 · 32:25 Shemos 32:32 Devarim 4:35 · 6:5 · 11:13 · 18:15
Nevi'im and Kesuvim	Melachim I 18:39 Yeshayahu 60:22 · Yirmiyahu 19:5 · Chavakuk 2:3 (via Sanhedrin 97b) Tehillim 11:5 · 60:6 · 69:2 · 89:35 · 90:4 · 119:126 Iyov 4:2
Mishnah and Talmud Bavli	Mishnah Berachos 9:5 Avos 1:3, 1:11 · 4:2 · 5:16 Berachos 61b · Pesachim 4a, 50b · Megillah 13b · Taanis 4a Sotah 31a · Nazir 23b · Yevamos 90b · Gittin 60b Bava Kamma 61a · Bava Basra 16a Sanhedrin 74a, 97a–b, 98a · Chullin 91a · Temurah 14b
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A NOTE ON THE TEXTS

Quotations follow the vocalized texts on Sefaria wherever one exists (for the Gemara, the William Davidson edition). A few passages are given without vocalization because no vocalized text was at hand: Avos DeRabbi Nosson, the Or Zarua, the Kitzur Baal HaTurim, the Pri Tzaddik on Lag BaOmer, and the Michtav MeEliyahu. The words of Rav Tzadok, the Mei HaShiloach, the Beis Yaakov and the other sources of the Akiva Publishing collection are quoted from its interlinear editions, and the Sha'arei Aharon from the text supplied, checked against the printed page. In quotations from Tanach the cantillation marks are omitted and the Divine Name is written ה׳. Where the shiur only alluded to a source, the source has been identified and quoted; English renderings of sources outside the collection were prepared for this edition. Rav Dessler's Kuntres HaBechirah is presented from the shiurim and articles listed above, and the volume itself was not consulted. Passages marked "source to be added" could not yet be traced.